

BEYOND THE TAJ · A CURATED INDIA BLUEPRINT

# Delhi to Manali

THE FOREIGNER'S FIELD MANUAL

PREPARED FOR

Jessica

FRANKFURT → DELHI → MANALI → SISSU → DELHI → HOME

8

DAYS

3

REGIONS

60+

CURATED STOPS

0

RIGID SCHEDULES



*India is not a country you visit on a schedule. It is a country you visit on permission — yours. This blueprint gives you the map. The rhythm is yours to set.*

— BEYONDTAJ, ON THE ONLY WAY TO TRAVEL THIS COUNTRY WELL

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*A blueprint, not a timetable. Move through this document in any order. The page numbers exist so you can return to anything in a hurry – at the airport, in a bus seat, mid-haggle in a Manali bazaar.*

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# A Letter For Jessica

Welcome to the blueprint. This document was written for you specifically — for the trip you *are about to take, the route you have chosen, and the questions you may not yet know to ask.*

**I**ndia is not a country you can travel through casually. It rewards preparation in ways most destinations do not. What overwhelms unprepared travelers becomes deeply meaningful for prepared ones — the noise becomes texture, the chaos becomes choreography, the strangeness becomes wonder. The difference, almost always, is what you knew before you arrived.

This blueprint exists because most India guides are written for the algorithm rather than for the person actually flying in. They list a hundred attractions without telling you which deserve a morning and which deserve five minutes. They publish "two-week itineraries" that schedule you down to the half-hour as if your nervous system is a corporate calendar. They show you the postcard but never the texture.

You will find none of that here. What you will find: a curated set of places, each one explained — what it actually is, what it actually costs, when it actually opens, how to actually reach it, and whether it is worth your time given the kind of traveler you are. Most days have no fixed schedule. You will see suggested clusters of places that sit near each other, you will know how to move between them, and you will choose your own rhythm. Some mornings you will want to walk for four hours. Some you will want to sit with a coffee until noon. Both are correct.

Two routes run through this guide. The first is geographical — Delhi to Manali to Sissu and back. The second is internal — the slow shift from arriving overwhelmed to arriving home changed. The first you can control with logistics. The second only India can give you, and only if you let it.

Trust the document. Trust your instincts more. And when something doesn't go to plan — and it won't, occasionally — remember that the best stories in travel are almost always the unplanned ones.

*Safe travels, Jessica. We will be a WhatsApp away the whole journey.*

— *BeyondTaj*

# What India Will Actually Feel Like

No country has worse marketing than India, and no country deserves better. Here is what to brace for — not to scare you, but so that none of it surprises you.

## The First Seventy-Two Hours

Your first three days will be louder, more crowded, and more colorful than you expected — even if you expected it. The airport exit hits you with heat, horns, drivers calling out, and the smell of a country that cooks, burns incense, and lives outdoors simultaneously. Your nervous system goes on alert. This is normal. Everyone feels this. Your job is not to fight it. Your job is to rest, hydrate, eat lightly, and let your system adjust. We will help you make this gentle.

## The Second Week Wall

Somewhere around day five or six, you may hit what we call the second-week wall — a documented stage of culture-shock recovery. Exhaustion arrives. Decision fatigue accumulates. You may cry for no clear reason. You may want to go home. This is functional, not pathological — your nervous system releasing accumulated stimulus. Almost no one who waits 48 hours past the worst moment actually leaves. Almost everyone who books a flight change at hour twelve regrets it. We have built rest into your route so this is gentler.

## What Nobody Tells You

India is *kind*. The hospitality is aggressive, overwhelming, and absolutely genuine. Strangers will feed you, help you, and refuse your money. India is also *exhausting* — there is no neutral gear, every minute outside your hotel requires active engagement with your environment. India is *beautiful* in a way that does not photograph well: the light at 6 a.m. on a Delhi ghat, a 70-year-old woman in a saffron saree carrying flowers to a temple, a Himalayan ridge turning pink as your bus rounds a corner. India is *frustrating*: buses run late, the WiFi drops mid-call, the hotel doesn't look like the photos. Flexibility is not optional. And India *changes* you. This sounds like brochure copy but it is documented — the majority of first-time India travelers describe the trip as one of the most significant experiences of their lives. Not because it is easy. Because it is complete.

#### THE ONE THING TO INTERNALIZE

India does not reward hurrying. The travelers who fight India lose. The ones who lean into it find magic. When something doesn't go to plan, do not escalate. Smile. Adjust. Ask a local. The country always has a workaround.

# Visa, Vaccines & Insurance

*The boring page that prevents the boring problems. Get these three things right and the rest is travel.*

## Your e-Tourist Visa

Germany is eligible for India's e-Tourist Visa (eTV). Apply online — never through a third-party site that charges 100+ USD. Application takes 30 minutes, approval takes 3–5 business days. Apply at minimum two weeks before your flight. We recommend three.

|                      |                                                            |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Official portal      | indianvisaonline.gov.in (only this URL)                    |
| Fee for Germans      | <b>25 USD</b> (30-day, double-entry)                       |
| Photo specs          | 2"×2", white background, JPEG, 10KB–1MB                    |
| Passport requirement | 6+ months validity from arrival, two blank pages minimum   |
| Processing time      | 3–5 business days normally; up to 7 in peak season         |
| What you carry       | The ETA email — printed, plus a digital copy on your phone |

### COMMON VISA MISTAKE

The #1 rejection cause is a non-compliant photo: any background other than white, glasses, hair covering your face, or wrong dimensions. Take a fresh photo at home with a white wall behind you and good light. Don't trust an old passport photo.

## Vaccines

See a travel-medicine doctor 4–6 weeks before departure. They will recommend a personalized list. The standard recommendations for your route are below — none are *legally* required for German citizens entering India, but they are clinically wise.



| VACCINE         | WHY                                                                            | LASTS               |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|
| Hepatitis A     | Food/water transmission. High risk in India.                                   | 25+ years (2 doses) |
| Typhoid         | Food/water transmission. Common in India.                                      | 2–5 years           |
| Routine updates | Tetanus, Polio, MMR, COVID-19, flu                                             | Check with doctor   |
| Hepatitis B     | If under 60 or any blood/fluid exposure risk                                   | 20+ years           |
| Rabies          | Optional. Recommended for rural travel or anyone uncomfortable around animals. | ~3 years            |

Malaria is **not** a concern for your specific route. Delhi and Manali are not malaria-endemic. Mosquito repellent is still useful for general comfort.

## Travel Insurance

This is non-negotiable, and the cheapest one isn't always wisest. Indian hospitals usually require upfront payment for treatment; insurance reimburses you later. Carry a credit card with enough limit to cover a serious hospital bill (50,000–200,000 INR / 600–2,400 USD), and pick a policy that covers what you will actually do.

|                      |                                                                                                                                |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| FOR MOST TRAVELERS   | <b>World Nomads</b> — covers light adventure activities including the bus journey to Manali. Approx. 60–110 USD for two weeks. |
| IF SOLANG ACTIVITIES | <b>Allianz Travel</b> with adventure rider — paragliding and ziplines need explicit coverage. Approx. 90–160 USD.              |
| FOR LONG STAYS       | <b>SafetyWing</b> — monthly subscription, ~45 USD/month. Best for stays over two weeks.                                        |
| MINIMUM COVER        | 100,000 USD medical, 250,000 USD emergency evacuation, plus baggage and trip-interruption cover.                               |



# Money — Cards, ATMs & UPI

*India is a cash-and-card hybrid economy that increasingly runs on QR codes. Here is the practical setup.*

## Before You Land

Notify your bank you are traveling to India. Without this, your card may freeze after the first ATM withdrawal in Delhi. If you have a fee-free travel card (Wise, Revolut, N26), bring it — international fees on standard German debit cards run 1.75–3% per transaction.

You do not need to bring rupees. Indian rupee exchange rates outside India are poor. Bring 200–300 EUR in cash as backup. Withdraw rupees from an ATM inside Delhi airport on arrival.

## At The ATM

|                              |                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| BEST BANKS TO USE            | SBI, HDFC, ICICI, Axis. Avoid Citibank India and small private bank ATMs — fees stack.                        |
| WITHDRAWAL LIMIT             | Usually 10,000 INR per transaction. You can do multiple transactions.                                         |
| ATM FEE                      | 27 INR per non-home-bank withdrawal (since May 2025) — withdraw in bulk to minimize cost.                     |
| RECOMMENDED FIRST WITHDRAWAL | 15,000–20,000 INR at the airport. Enough for first three days.                                                |
| CURRENCY CONVERSION TRICK    | If the ATM asks "convert to EUR or proceed in INR?" — <b>always proceed in INR.</b> Conversion fees are 3–5%. |

## Cash vs Card vs UPI

| WHERE                  | BEST PAYMENT           | WHY                                     |
|------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Hotels (3-star+)       | Card or UPI            | Accepted, no fees, records for receipts |
| Restaurants (sit-down) | Card or UPI            | Cards accepted in most places           |
| Street food            | Cash (small notes)     | Card rarely accepted, small amounts     |
| Auto-rickshaws         | Cash or Uber/Ola pay   | App rides bill your card automatically  |
| Markets / shops        | Cash for bargaining    | Bargaining for card is awkward          |
| Manali cafés           | Cash + occasional card | Smaller cafés often cash-only           |
| Tips                   | Cash, small notes      | Always rupees, never foreign currency   |

## UPI For Tourists (2026)

India's UPI payment system now accepts foreign tourists from 40+ countries (Germany included) via the **UPI One World** program. Setup happens at Delhi Airport at partner bank kiosks. It takes 20 minutes. After setup, you scan QR codes to pay anywhere — including street vendors. Eliminates handling cash for most transactions. We strongly recommend setting this up on arrival.

### THE SMALL NOTES RULE

Always keep 10, 20, 50, and 100 INR notes in a separate pocket. Vendors "cannot make change" for a 500-rupee note constantly — sometimes genuinely, sometimes as a soft scam to keep your change. Break large notes at hotels or large stores immediately.

# SIM Card & The Apps That Matter

*A working Indian phone number is the single most important thing for a smooth trip. Buy it at the airport, the moment you land.*

## Where & What To Buy

Inside the arrivals hall at Delhi Airport (Terminal 3), official Jio and Airtel counters operate 24/7. Buy from these — never from kiosks outside the terminal, never from anyone who approaches you. Both networks work well in Delhi and Manali. Bring your passport and a passport-size photo (carry 4 from home; you will need them for permits in Manali too).

|                  |                                                                                                         |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| RECOMMENDED PLAN | <b>Jio 28-day Tourist Plan</b> — approx. 600 INR. Includes 2GB/day data + unlimited calls within India. |
| ALTERNATIVE      | <b>Airtel 28-day Plan</b> — approx. 700 INR. Marginally better mountain coverage.                       |
| ACTIVATION TIME  | 2–4 hours typical. Buy on arrival; it will be live by the time you reach your hotel.                    |
| DOCUMENTS        | Passport + visa + one photo + Indian address (your hotel works)                                         |

### ESIM ALTERNATIVE

**Airalo** or **Holafly** offer India eSIMs you can buy and activate before leaving Germany. Data-only — no Indian phone number, which limits Uber registration and OTP-based services. Best as a backup to the physical Jio/Airtel SIM, not a replacement.

## Apps To Install Before The Flight

Install everything below before you board. Connect to airport WiFi only briefly on arrival — the SIM activates quickly. Make sure each app is set up with your account and ready.

| APP                | WHAT IT DOES                  | WHY IT MATTERS                                  |
|--------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Uber               | Ride-hailing (cars & autos)   | Most reliable transport in Delhi                |
| Ola                | Indian Uber equivalent        | Sometimes better availability than Uber         |
| Google Maps        | Navigation + offline maps     | Download Delhi & Manali offline maps            |
| Google Translate   | Translation + camera OCR      | Download Hindi pack for offline use             |
| WhatsApp           | Messaging                     | Everyone uses this — hotels, drivers, BeyondTaj |
| redBus             | Bus booking                   | For the Delhi → Manali sleeper                  |
| Zomato             | Restaurant reviews + delivery | Trust 4.0+ rated places. Order to hotel.        |
| Practo             | Telemedicine + doctors        | 500 INR for English-speaking doctor by video    |
| 1mg                | Pharmacy + medicine delivery  | Medicine to your hotel in 1–2 hours             |
| IRCTC Rail Connect | Train booking                 | Optional — for return trains                    |
| XE Currency        | Live exchange rates           | Sanity check on prices in EUR                   |
| 112 India          | Emergency SOS                 | Official emergency app — preset SOS contacts    |

# Weather, Timing & Packing Philosophy

A full packing checklist appears on page 46. This page is about the thinking — what kind of clothes, why, and what to actually buy in India instead of bringing.

## The Weather You Will Encounter

| LOCATION                | DAY                       | NIGHT   | NOTES                                   |
|-------------------------|---------------------------|---------|-----------------------------------------|
| Delhi (Oct–Mar)         | 18–25°C                   | 5–12°C  | Dry, sunny, occasional smog late Nov    |
| Delhi (Apr–Jun)         | 35–45°C                   | 25–32°C | Brutal heat — avoid afternoons outside  |
| Delhi (Jul–Sep)         | 28–35°C                   | 22–28°C | Monsoon — humid, daily afternoon rain   |
| Manali (Apr–Jun)        | 15–25°C                   | 5–10°C  | Pleasant, snow remains on higher ridges |
| Manali (Jul–Sep)        | 15–22°C                   | 10–14°C | Some rain, lush green landscapes        |
| Manali (Oct–Dec)        | 5–15°C                    | 0–5°C   | Crisp, possible early snow late Dec     |
| Manali (Jan–Mar)        | 0–10°C                    | –5–2°C  | Snow season — beautiful, layer up       |
| Sissu (Year-round, day) | +3–5°C cooler than Manali | —       | Always pack a warmer layer for Sissu    |

## The Packing Philosophy

Pack lighter than you think. India has functional, fast laundry services everywhere — 50–100 INR per bag, returned the same day at most hotels. Pack five days of clothing maximum, regardless of trip length.

Cotton is king. India's heat, even when mild, makes synthetics uncomfortable. Bring loose cotton or linen pieces. Tight-fitting western clothing draws unnecessary attention in Delhi neighborhoods. A long scarf or large cotton wrap doubles as temple cover, sun protection, and emergency blanket on the bus.

## What To Buy In India Instead Of Bringing

|                        |                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| COTTON KURTAS          | Three or four loose tops for under 1,500 INR (~17 EUR) at Janpath market or Dilli Haat. More comfortable than anything you own. |
| SCARVES & DUPATTAS     | 100–500 INR each. Essential for temples, sunshine, dust.                                                                        |
| MEDICAL KIT            | Buy the full kit on Day 1 at any pharmacy for ~500 INR. See the Health page.                                                    |
| POWER ADAPTER          | India uses Type C/D/M sockets. A 200 INR universal adapter at any electronics shop covers everything. Avoid airport prices.     |
| WARM LAYERS FOR MANALI | Manali Mall Road sells fleeces and wool sweaters for 800–1,500 INR. Lighter to buy on arrival than to fly with.                 |
| TOILET PAPER           | Pack a starter pack. Restock in India at any pharmacy — 60 INR/roll. Not provided in most public toilets.                       |

### WHAT NOT TO BRING

Drone (illegal without DGCA license; will be confiscated). Vape/e-cigarettes (banned since 2019). More than 2 liters of alcohol (customs limit). Anything camouflage-patterned (restricted for tourists). Heavy jeans (too hot for Delhi, unnecessary for Manali). Strong perfumes (attract mosquitoes).

# The Delhi Metro, Decoded

*The Delhi Metro is clean, modern, air-conditioned, fast, cheap, and safe. Once you understand it, you can reach every place in this blueprint for under 60 INR. Here is the complete primer.*

## The Lines You Will Actually Use

|                                     |                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>AIRPORT EXPRESS<br/>(ORANGE)</b> | Terminal 3 → New Delhi Railway Station in 22 minutes. Fare 60 INR. Fastest airport route if your hotel is near central Delhi.                 |
| <b>YELLOW LINE</b>                  | North-south spine. Connects Chandni Chowk (Old Delhi) ↔ Connaught Place (Rajiv Chowk) ↔ Saket ↔ Qutub Minar. You will use this line the most. |
| <b>VIOLET LINE</b>                  | Central Delhi access. Passes JLN Stadium (for Lodhi Garden), Khan Market, Jangpura, Lajpat Nagar.                                             |
| <b>PINK LINE</b>                    | Crosses the city laterally. Useful for Lajpat Nagar ↔ Hauz Khas without changing lines.                                                       |
| <b>MAGENTA LINE</b>                 | Hauz Khas ↔ Hauz Khas Village area, plus Janakpuri and IGI Terminal 1 (domestic).                                                             |

## Buying A Ticket — Three Options

1

### Single-Journey Token (For Tourists)

At any station, go to the counter or ticket machine. Tell the agent your destination. They give you a plastic token. Fares range 10–60 INR. Touch the token on the gate sensor to enter; drop it in the slot to exit.

2

### Tourist Smart Card

If you plan to use the Metro 4+ times, buy a Tourist Card — 200 INR for 1 day unlimited, or 500 INR for 3 days unlimited. Sold at airport and major station counters. Worth it for active sightseeing days.

3

### DMRC App + QR Tickets

Download the DMRC Travel App. Buy QR-code tickets on your phone, scan at the gate. Useful if queues are long. Requires Indian phone number for OTP.



## Metro Etiquette You Should Know

- **The first car is women-only.** Look for the pink stripe on the platform. Solo female travelers are encouraged to use it during rush hours.
- **Security check at every entrance.** Bags go through scanners; you walk through metal detectors. Allow 3–5 minutes extra at busy stations.
- **Operating hours.** Roughly 6 a.m. to 11 p.m. Don't plan a late-night metro return.
- **No eating, drinking, or photography** inside stations or trains. The last is enforced.
- **Avoid 8:30–10 a.m. and 5:30–8 p.m.** Rush hour on the Yellow Line is genuinely uncomfortable.

### WHEN TO USE METRO OVER UBER

Use the metro for longer cross-city trips during the day — it cuts through Delhi's traffic, which can turn a 7-km Uber ride into a 60-minute crawl. Use Uber/Ola for short hops (under 3 km), at night, with luggage, or when you are tired. The metro is safer for solo women than any other transport.

# Uber, Ola & The Auto-Rickshaw

*Apps are the foreigner's friend in India. They eliminate the negotiation, set a transparent price, and create a digital record. Here is how to use them properly.*

## Uber Vs Ola — What's The Difference?

Both work, both are reliable in Delhi, both are cheaper than European taxi apps by a wide margin. Ola often has slightly better availability and is sometimes cheaper. Uber is more familiar interface-wise for Western travelers. We recommend installing both before you fly — when one shows a 10-minute wait or surge pricing, the other might not. Toggle between them.

## The Vehicle Categories

|                                       |                                                                                                                                             |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>UBER AUTO / OLA AUTO</b>           | Three-wheeler auto-rickshaw. Cheapest. Best for short distances (under 5 km). No AC, exposed to traffic noise but agile through congestion. |
| <b>UBER GO / OLA MINI</b>             | Compact car (usually Maruti Swift). Cheapest enclosed option with AC. Fine for 1–2 passengers with a small bag.                             |
| <b>UBER PREMIER / OLA PRIME SEDAN</b> | Mid-size sedan (Honda City, Hyundai Verna). More comfortable, ~30% more expensive. Best for airport runs with luggage.                      |
| <b>UBER XL / OLA SUV</b>              | Larger vehicles. Worth it for 3+ passengers or longer routes outside Delhi.                                                                 |

## Expected Fares — Sanity Check

| ROUTE                                 | UBER GO     | UBER AUTO   |
|---------------------------------------|-------------|-------------|
| Airport → Connaught Place (15 km)     | 450–700 INR | 300–450 INR |
| Connaught Place → Old Delhi (5 km)    | 150–250 INR | 80–130 INR  |
| Connaught Place → Hauz Khas (10 km)   | 300–450 INR | 180–280 INR |
| Connaught Place → Qutub Minar (16 km) | 400–600 INR | 250–400 INR |
| Hotel → ISBT Kashmiri Gate (varies)   | 300–550 INR | 180–350 INR |

## Off-App Auto-Rickshaws

Sometimes you will hail an auto from the street — outside a monument, in Old Delhi where Uber pickup zones are awkward. The script:

1. **Always ask "meter chalu karo?"** — "start the meter?" — before getting in. If they refuse, walk away. There are always more autos.
2. **If they refuse the meter**, agree a flat fare in advance. Reference the Uber price (open the app) and add 15–25%. Quote that price firmly.
3. **Never pay before getting out.** Pay at the destination, exact change if possible.
4. **Don't tip auto drivers.** It's not the custom. Rounding up to the next 10 is generous.

### THE AUTO SCAMS TO REFUSE

"Meter broken." The meter is fine — they just want to negotiate up. Walk away. "I'll take you somewhere better." They will take you to a shop that pays commission. Walk away. "Your hotel is closed/full/changed location." Your hotel is fine. Call the hotel directly. Walk away.

# Trains, Buses & Domestic Flights

For Delhi → Manali, you will take an overnight bus — covered in detail on page 27. This page covers the broader intercity transport landscape, in case you extend or change plans.

## Domestic Flights

India's domestic flight network is excellent. IndiGo, Air India, SpiceJet, Vistara, and Akasa fly between every major city for 3,000–9,000 INR (35–105 USD) one-way if booked even a week ahead. For your trip, the only relevant route is the optional Delhi ↔ Kullu-Bhuntar flight (the closest airport to Manali, 50 km south).

| ROUTE                      | TIME   | TYPICAL FARE         |
|----------------------------|--------|----------------------|
| Delhi → Kullu-Bhuntar      | 1h 30m | 5,000–9,000 INR      |
| Bhuntar → Manali (by road) | 1h 30m | 1,500–2,500 INR taxi |

The Bhuntar flight is weather-dependent and frequently cancelled in monsoon (Jul-Sep) and winter (Dec-Feb). For your trip, the bus is more reliable.

## Trains

There is no train to Manali — the nearest station is Chandigarh, still 8 hours by road. Trains are excellent for other Indian travel, but irrelevant for this route. If you extend your trip to Rajasthan or Varanasi, the train is comfortable and culturally fascinating. Book through IRCTC.co.in or the Rail Connect app.

## Long-Distance Buses

For Delhi → Manali, buses are the main option — 540 km, 12–14 hours overnight, 800–2,200 INR depending on class. The detailed bus guide is on page 27. Brief summary of classes:

| CLASS                 | FARE            | REALITY                                                  |
|-----------------------|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Seater (Non-AC)       | 800–1,000 INR   | Recliner seats. Not recommended for 13 hours.            |
| Sleeper (Non-AC)      | 1,000–1,400 INR | Berths with curtains. Cold in mountains.                 |
| Volvo AC Sleeper      | 1,500–2,200 INR | <b>Our recommendation.</b> Reclining berth, blanket, AC. |
| ZingBus Max / Premium | 2,000–2,500 INR | Best-in-class: meal included, hygiene kit, large berths. |

## Private Drivers

For Delhi-only sightseeing, a hired car with driver is often more efficient than apps if you are doing 5+ stops in a day. Approximate full-day rate: 2,500–4,000 INR including fuel and parking. Book through your hotel or via OLA Outstation. You skip the constant app-booking and the driver waits while you sightsee.

### WHEN TO HIRE A DRIVER FOR THE DAY

If your day spans Old Delhi → Humayun's Tomb → Hauz Khas → Qutub Minar (the "all the monuments" day), a hired car saves ~90 minutes of app booking and waiting. Otherwise, Uber + Metro is more flexible and cheaper.



PART THREE · DELHI

*A capital city — and three  
cities stacked on top of each  
other.*

# Landing & Your First 24 Hours

Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGI / DEL) is one of Asia's busiest. Here is exactly what to do from the moment your wheels touch the tarmac.

## The Exit Sequence

- 1

**Immigration — Look For The e-Visa Lane**

It is separate from the regular foreigner queue and usually shorter. Have your printed ETA (or a clear photo on your phone), return ticket, and hotel booking ready to show. Biometrics (fingerprints) are routine — this is normal.
- 2

**Baggage Collect & Customs**

Customs is straightforward. Walk through the green channel unless you have items to declare. Electronics for personal use are fine.
- 3

**ATM + SIM Card + UPI Setup**

Inside arrivals, before you exit: visit an SBI/HDFC ATM (withdraw 15,000–20,000 INR). Then visit the Jio or Airtel counter for your SIM. If UPI One World is available, set it up at the partner bank kiosk. Total time: 30–45 minutes.
- 4

**Walk Past The Touts**

The moment you exit the terminal, drivers will approach offering "special prices." Walk past all of them without making eye contact. Do not engage. Your transport is already arranged via app or prepaid taxi counter.

## Getting To Your Hotel — Three Good Options

| METHOD                              | TO CONNAUGHT PLACE | TO SOUTH DELHI  | NOTES                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Uber / Ola                          | 450–700 INR        | 550–900 INR     | Most flexible. App pickup zone is signed outside arrivals.                     |
| Prepaid Taxi (Delhi Traffic Police) | 500–700 INR        | 600–900 INR     | Counter inside arrivals hall. Yellow signage. Receipt-based, zero negotiation. |
| Airport Metro Express               | 60 INR             | Less convenient | 22 min to New Delhi Station. Skip with heavy luggage.                          |

#### THE AIRPORT TAXI SCAM

Random drivers may quote 2,000–4,000 INR for a 15 km trip. The genuine fare is 450–700 INR. Anyone quoting 1,500+ is scamming you. Stick to the Uber app or the official prepaid taxi counter *inside* the terminal — the one with the police uniform desk. Do not negotiate with anyone outside.

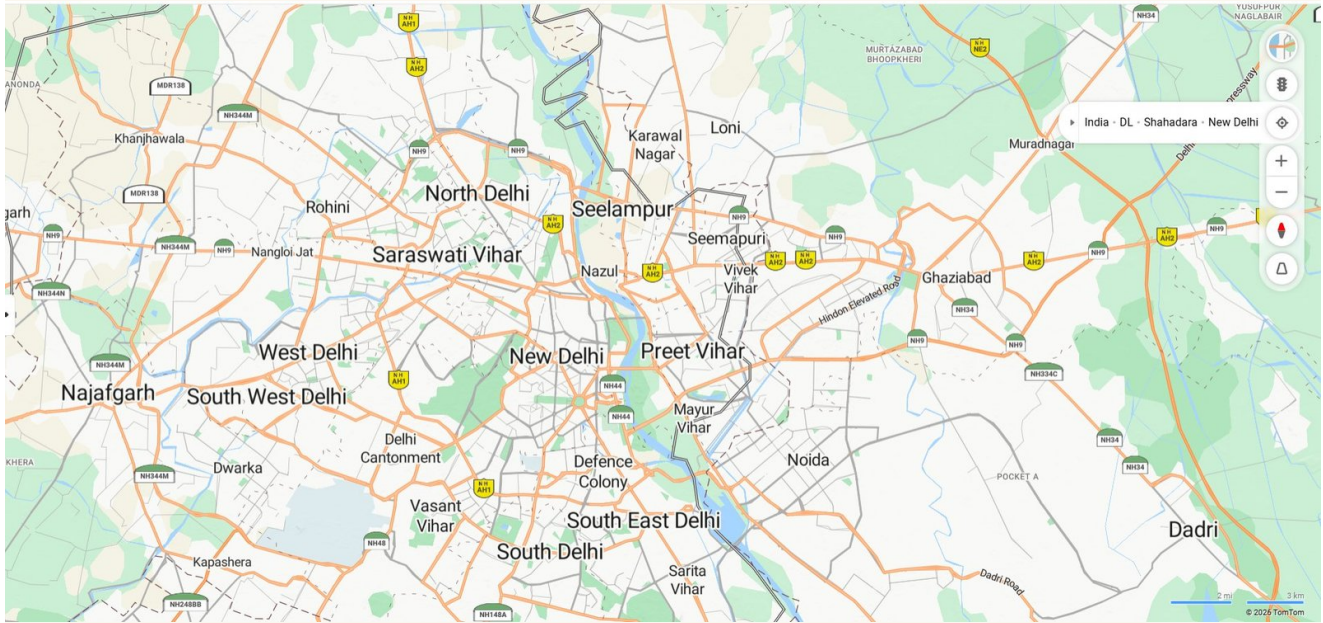
## Your First Evening — Be Gentle With Yourself

Do not plan anything for your arrival evening. Eat at your hotel restaurant. Drink three liters of water. Sleep early. Jet lag plus India arrival is real, and aggressive sightseeing on Day 1 ends in either exhaustion or illness. Day 2 onward, the city is yours.



# Where To Sleep In Delhi

Delhi is huge. Where you sleep matters more than which monument you visit. These are the four neighborhoods we recommend, in order of preference.



GREATER DELHI · your sleeping neighborhoods are concentrated in the central and south zones

## South Delhi — Our First Recommendation

Quiet residential streets, leafy parks, excellent restaurants, the country's best museums, and good metro connectivity. Solo female travelers feel safest here. Neighborhoods to focus on: **Hauz Khas, Defence Colony, Greater Kailash, Saket, Lodhi Estate.**

### MID-RANGE · SOUTH DELHI

#### The Manor FRIENDS COLONY

8,000–14,000 INR / night · book on the hotel website or via MakeMyTrip

A 14-room boutique hotel inside a residential bungalow. Quiet, beautifully designed, excellent restaurant. Best for travelers who want a calm base.

MID-RANGE • SOUTH DELHI

### **Bloomrooms @ New Delhi Janpath** JANPATH

3,500–5,500 INR / night • [MakeMyTrip](#) or [Booking.com](#)

Bright, modern, scrupulously clean. Walking distance to Janpath market and Connaught Place. Best value in central Delhi.

## **Aerocity — Near The Airport**

A purpose-built hotel district 5 minutes from the airport. International chains. Useful for one-night arrivals before flying onward, or for departure-day stays. Not central — 25–40 minutes to monuments. Lacks Delhi character, but a controlled, low-stress base.

MID-RANGE • AEROCITY

### **Holiday Inn Express Aerocity**

5,500–8,500 INR / night • [Holiday Inn website](#)

International standard, free breakfast, 24-hour shuttle to airport. Best first-night choice if you arrive late.

## **Central Delhi / Connaught Place — Central But Busy**

The geographic heart. Convenient for all monuments. Can be noisy. Decent for one to two nights, but South Delhi is calmer for a longer stay.

PREMIUM • CENTRAL DELHI

### **The Imperial New Delhi**

18,000–35,000 INR / night • [the-imperial.com](#)

A genuine landmark since 1931 — Art Deco architecture, original art, lawns. One of India's most storied hotels. Worth it for at least one night of your life.

## **What To Avoid**

**Paharganj** — the backpacker district near New Delhi Railway Station — is fine in daylight, draining at night, and best avoided unless you are a confident budget backpacker on a tight budget. The streets

are narrow, the touts persistent, and the noise relentless. The savings (around 1,500 INR/night vs South Delhi mid-range) are not worth it for a foreign traveler.

**Old Delhi** — staying inside Old Delhi is for very experienced travelers only. It is incredible to visit but exhausting to wake up in.

#### BOOKING STRATEGY

Book your first two nights firmly before flying. Leave any additional Delhi nights flexible — Booking.com and MakeMyTrip have generous cancellation policies on Indian mid-range hotels. Pay in INR (not your home currency) when given the option.

# Old Delhi — Mughal Bones

Old Delhi is sensory overload at its finest. These five places sit within walking distance of each other. Pick two or three for a half-day, or all five for a full day with breaks.



CHANDNI CHOWK LANES · morning light, slow rickshaws



THE MUSLIM QUARTER NEAR JAMA MASJID · perfumers, bookshops, festoons

## Red Fort · Lal Qila

UNESCO · 16TH C.

ENTRY **600 INR foreigners** TIME **90–120 min** BEST HOUR **9:30–11 a.m.** CLOSED **Mondays**

NEAREST METRO **Lal Qila (Violet)**

The political heart of Mughal India. The Diwan-i-Aam (Hall of Public Audiences) and Diwan-i-Khas (Hall of Private Audiences) are stunning. The complex feels less impressive than it should because much of the interior is sparsely furnished and the fountains run dry — but the architecture, the gates, and the marble inlay reward slow looking.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Enter via Lahori Gate. Skip the sound-and-light show in the evening — it's dated. The audio guide (200 INR) is decent if you don't have a human guide.

## Jama Masjid

17TH C. • MOSQUE

ENTRY **Free** CAMERA FEE **300 INR** MINARET CLIMB **100 INR** TIME **45–60 min**

DRESS CODE **Modest, head cover for women**

One of the largest mosques in Asia, completed by Shah Jahan in 1656. 25,000 people pray here on Fridays. The climb up the southern minaret (slightly claustrophobic spiral staircase) rewards you with the best ground-level view of Old Delhi — a sea of rooftops, satellite dishes, and the Red Fort beyond. Borrowed robes available at entrance.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Avoid Friday prayer hours (1–2 p.m.) unless you are praying. Floor stones become unbearably hot 11 a.m. to 4 p.m. in summer — they require you to remove your shoes. Bring socks.

## Chandni Chowk

MARKET • 17TH C.

ENTRY **Free** TIME **2–3 hours** BEST HOUR **10 a.m. or 5 p.m.**

BEST WITH **A local guide (1,500–2,500 INR)**

The 400-year-old central market street of Old Delhi, lined with lanes that specialize: spices on Khari Baoli, jewelry on Dariba Kalan, paper and books on Nai Sarak, paratha on Paranthi Wali Gali. Get lost intentionally. The lanes are narrow, motorbikes share them with pedestrians, and the chaos is the entire point.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

A walking food tour (try Delhi Food Walks or Master Chef Tours, both around 2,500–3,500 INR for 3 hours) transforms Chandni Chowk from intimidating to fascinating. Worth booking for your first Old Delhi visit. Otherwise, eat at Paranthi Wali Gali — the 300-year-old paratha lane — and have a kulfi at Kuremal Mohanlal Kulfiwale.

## Old Delhi (continued)

### Karim's · The Original Mughlai

SINCE 1913 · RESTAURANT

MEAL COST 500–900 INR / person TIME 60–90 min

OPEN 9 a.m.–midnight (closed during Ramadan days) LOCATION Gali Kababian, beside Jama Masjid

A 110-year-old Mughlai institution started by the descendant of a chef in the imperial kitchens. Mutton korma, mutton burra, seekh kebab, butter chicken — all done the original way. Casual, simple, unfussy. The food is the point. Pair Jama Masjid + Karim's into a single morning.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Non-vegetarian only. Avoid lunch rush (1–3 p.m.) — go at 11:30 a.m. or after 7:30 p.m. for shorter waits. Several "Karim's" exist across Delhi but the Jama Masjid original is the one.

### Spice Market · Khari Baoli

WHOLESALE MARKET · ASIA'S LARGEST

ENTRY Free TIME 30–60 min BEST HOUR 10–11 a.m. CLOSED Sundays

The largest wholesale spice market in Asia. Sacks of red chili, turmeric, cardamom, dried fruits, and saffron line every wall. You will sneeze constantly from chili dust in the air — this is normal and lasts 15 minutes after leaving. Buy small portions of whole spices to take home (cardamom, saffron, garam masala) at fair prices.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Climb up the staircase at any spice shop entrance to the rooftop — most shops will let you (sometimes 50 INR tip). The rooftop view of stacked spice sacks below is unforgettable. Honest shops: Roshan Di Kulfī, Mehar Chand & Sons.

## Building A Day Around Old Delhi

#### IF YOU HAVE A FULL DAY

**Morning:** Red Fort opens at 9:30. Start there. **Late morning:** Walk south to Jama Masjid, climb the minaret. **Lunch:** Karim's, around the corner. **Afternoon:** Cycle-rickshaw or walk to Chandni Chowk's lanes — Paranthe Wali Gali for snack, Khari Baoli spice market. **Late afternoon:** Metro back to your hotel from Chandni Chowk station (Yellow Line). You will be exhausted but happy.

#### IF YOU HAVE HALF A DAY

**Option A — History focus:** Red Fort + Jama Masjid + Karim's lunch. End by 2 p.m. **Option B — Market focus:** Chandni Chowk + Khari Baoli + Paranthe Wali Gali. Skip the monuments. **Option C — Photography:** Arrive at Jama Masjid by 6:30 a.m., climb the minaret at sunrise (call ahead to confirm opening — sometimes earlier), then walk the empty Chandni Chowk lanes before they fill up.

#### OLD DELHI SURVIVAL NOTES

Carry water and tissues. Wear shoes you can slip off (mosque entry). Keep your phone in your front pocket, not back. Cycle-rickshaws can be useful inside Chandni Chowk lanes (50–100 INR for short hops) — they fit where autos cannot. Bring your most flexible patience — this place rewards calm.



# Central Delhi — Imperial Spine

Lutyens' New Delhi was designed by the British in the 1910s as the imperial capital. Wide boulevards, sandstone government buildings, and green spaces stitched together by monuments. This is Delhi at its most ceremonial.

## Humayun's Tomb

UNESCO · 1565

ENTRY 600 INR foreigners TIME 90 min BEST HOUR 7:30–9 a.m. or 4:30 p.m.

NEAREST METRO JLN Stadium (Violet)

The architectural precursor to the Taj Mahal — built by Humayun's widow 80 years before the Taj. The first garden-tomb in the Indian subcontinent. Pristine, contemplative, almost always less crowded than the Taj. We rate this as the single most rewarding monument in Delhi for foreign visitors.

The complex includes **Isa Khan's Tomb** — an octagonal Lodi-era tomb older than Humayun's, with stunning blue tile work. Sundar Nursery is across the road — 90 acres of restored Mughal gardens, perfect for an evening walk.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Visit at sunrise (entry from 6 a.m. November through February). The light on the red sandstone is the best in Delhi. Bring a hired guide for 600–1,000 INR — the history transforms the place.



ISA KHAN'S TOMB · Humayun's complex · the photo most travelers leave with



INDIA GATE AT NIGHT · tricolor lighting, families on Kartavya Path



## Lodhi Garden

PARK · 15TH C. TOMBS

ENTRY **Free** TIME **60–90 min** BEST HOUR **6:30–9 a.m. or 5–7 p.m.**

NEAREST METRO **JLN Stadium (Violet)**

90 acres of green in the middle of New Delhi, dotted with 15th-century Lodi and Sayyid dynasty tombs. The park where Delhi's residents actually live their lives — joggers, yoga groups, lovers on benches, aunties power-walking in clusters of three. The five tombs (Mohammed Shah, Sikander Lodi, Bara Gumbad, Sheesh Gumbad, Bada Khan) are open-walk monuments — no tickets needed.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Combine with breakfast at Lodi The Garden Restaurant (inside the park) or Khan Market's All American Diner. Lodhi Art District (street art murals on residential walls) is 10 minutes away.

## India Gate & Kartavya Path

WAR MEMORIAL · 1931

ENTRY **Free** TIME **30–60 min** BEST HOUR **After dark (illuminated)**

NEAREST METRO **Central Secretariat (Yellow)**

The 42-meter sandstone arch commemorating Indian soldiers who died in WWI. Inspired by the Arc de Triomphe but completely Indian in feel — surrounded by lawns where families picnic at all hours. Best visited after dark when illuminated and cooler. The ceremonial avenue (Kartavya Path, formerly Rajpath) stretches west toward Rashtrapati Bhavan (President's residence).

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Buy a paper cone of *bhel puri* from a vendor and walk the length of Kartavya Path at dusk. Pedestrian-only since 2022. The walk is genuinely beautiful, much underrated.

## Central Delhi (continued)

### Khan Market

MARKET · UPMARKET BAZAAR

ENTRY **Free** TIME **2–3 hours** BEST HOUR **After 12 noon (many shops open late)**

CLOSED **Sundays (most shops)**

Delhi's most beloved upscale market — bookshops, boutiques, bakeries, perfume shops, and restaurants. Diplomatic-quarter clientele, slow pace, no touts. **The Good Earth** (home design), **Faqir Chand Bookstore** (independent literature), **Bahrasons** (Delhi's oldest bookshop), and **Anokhi** (block-printed textiles) are the standouts.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

The "Khan Market" most foreign tourists assume to be busy is actually two-level — explore the upper floors above the famous storefronts. Half the best shops are upstairs. Pair this with lunch at SodaBottleOpenerWala or The Big Chill.

### Agrasen Ki Baoli

STEPWELL · 14TH C.

ENTRY **Free** TIME **30 min** BEST HOUR **9–10 a.m.** LOCATION **Hailey Road, near Connaught Place**

A 14th-century stepwell hidden in the middle of corporate Delhi — surrounded by office buildings, completely incongruous. 108 stone steps descend in a symmetric V to where water once was. Atmospheric, slightly eerie, perfect for photography. Featured in Bollywood films, surprisingly low-touristed.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Walk in flat-soled shoes — the steps are uneven. Bats live in the upper galleries; harmless but you may hear them. Combine with Connaught Place coffee.

## National Museum

MUSEUM · NATIONAL COLLECTION

ENTRY **650 INR foreigners** AUDIO GUIDE **150 INR (worth it)** TIME **2–3 hours**

CLOSED **Mondays + national holidays**

India's largest museum — 5,000 years of artifacts. Skip the casual rooms and go directly to the Indus Valley collection (3000 BCE), the Buddhist art galleries, and the miniature painting collection. Underrated and never crowded. Best for travelers who want context on what they will see in Manali and beyond.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Visit early in your trip if at all — it gives meaning to everything else you see. Camera fee is 300 INR extra; many photographs are restricted.

## Building A Central Delhi Half-Day

### A SLOW IMPERIAL MORNING

**Sunrise:** Humayun's Tomb at opening. **Mid-morning:** Walk in Sundar Nursery next door. **Late morning:** Taxi to Lodhi Garden. Tomb walks + breakfast at a Lodi-area café. **Lunch:** Khan Market — SodaBottleOpenerWala (Parsi food) or Indian Accent (fine dining, book ahead). **Afternoon:** Optional: National Museum. Or rest. **Evening:** India Gate after dark.

# South Delhi — Ruins & Cafés

If Old Delhi is Mughal Delhi and Central Delhi is Imperial Delhi, South Delhi is Contemporary Delhi — but built on top of 800 years of older Delhi, with ruined tombs and stepwells inside residential neighborhoods.

## Qutub Minar Complex

UNESCO · 1193

ENTRY **600 INR foreigners** TIME **90 min** BEST HOUR **7:30–9 a.m.**NEAREST METRO **Qutab Minar (Yellow) + 10-min ride**

The 73-meter brick minaret built starting 1193 — the tallest of its kind in the world. The complex contains the Quwwat-ul-Islam Mosque (India's first), the Iron Pillar (a 1,600-year-old rust-free metallurgical mystery), and the unfinished Alai Minar (intended to be twice the height of Qutub Minar but abandoned). Quietly extraordinary.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Mehrauli Archaeological Park is adjacent — 200 acres of ruins, almost no tourists. Walk 15 minutes south of Qutub Minar to enter. Jamali Kamali Tomb is the highlight. Bring water; little shade.

## Hauz Khas Village & Ruins

14TH C. COMPLEX · HIPSTER QUARTER

ENTRY **Free** TIME **2–3 hours** BEST HOUR **3 p.m. (ruins) → dusk (village)**NEAREST METRO **Green Park or IIT (Yellow)**

A 14th-century reservoir (hauz = tank, khas = royal) and ruined Islamic seminary, now surrounded by Delhi's hippest neighborhood. The ruins themselves are atmospheric — half-restored, half-overgrown, with deer in the adjacent park. The village around it has hundreds of boutiques, art galleries, cocktail bars, and rooftop cafés. The combination of medieval ruins + craft beer is unique to Delhi.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Walk the ruins at 4–5 p.m., then have early dinner at one of the village rooftops with ruin views. Smoke House Deli, Naivedyam, Yeti, Coast Café all overlook the ruins. The deer park behind is rarely visited and beautiful at golden hour.

## ISKCON Temple

HARE KRISHNA · 1998

ENTRY **Free**    TIME **45 min**    BEST HOUR **Evening aarti (~7 p.m.)**    DRESS CODE **Modest, shoes off**

A working Hare Krishna temple — built in marble, beautifully landscaped, air-conditioned interior. Open to all faiths. The evening aarti (prayer ritual with music) is genuinely moving even for non-religious visitors. The on-site Govinda's restaurant serves a clean vegetarian buffet (~400 INR all-you-can-eat) — useful for travelers with stomach concerns.

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### BEYONDTAJ TIP

*Skip the "Vedic museum" attraction — paid, dated, skippable. The temple itself and the gardens are the experience.*

## South Delhi (continued)

### Dilli Haat (INA)

GOVERNMENT CRAFTS MARKET

ENTRY **100 INR foreigners** TIME **2 hours** BEST HOUR **11 a.m. or 5 p.m.**

NEAREST METRO **INA Market (Yellow)**

An open-air crafts village where artisans from all 28 Indian states rotate in for two-week residencies. Each state has its own stall — Kashmiri shawls, Rajasthani puppets, Bengali muslin, Madhubani painting, tribal jewelry from Jharkhand. Prices are quasi-fixed (gentle bargaining accepted, but not the chaos of street markets). Government-run, so authentic and not exploitative.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

The best place in Delhi to buy souvenirs — better quality and fairer prices than the airport, Janpath, or hotel shops. The food court at the back has state-specific dishes you won't find elsewhere — try the Sikkimese momos or Kashmiri rogan josh.

### Lodhi Art District

STREET ART · OPEN AIR

ENTRY **Free** TIME **60–90 min walk** BEST HOUR **3–5 p.m. (good light)**

LOCATION **Lodi Colony residential blocks**

India's first public art district — entire residential building facades painted by Indian and international street artists. Started in 2015, now 60+ murals. A self-guided walk through Lodi Colony reveals the works one at a time, set against ordinary residential life — kids on bikes, aunties hanging laundry, the murals towering above. Surprising and joyful.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Combine with Lodhi Garden across the road. Pick up coffee at Khoj or Lodi The Garden Restaurant beforehand. Google "Lodhi Art District map" for a self-guided route.

## Building A South Delhi Day

#### A FULL DAY, SLOW PACE

**Morning:** Qutub Minar at 8 a.m. opening. **Late morning:** Walk Mehrauli Archaeological Park. **Lunch:** Hauz Khas Village — Naivedyam (South Indian) or Yeti (Tibetan). **Afternoon:** Hauz Khas ruins + Deer Park. **Late afternoon:** Dilli Haat for shopping. **Evening:** ISKCON aarti at 7 p.m. or rest. **Dinner:** Anywhere — South Delhi has Delhi's best dining scene.

#### A HALF DAY, HIGHLIGHTS ONLY

Qutub Minar (90 min) + Hauz Khas (2 hours including lunch). Skip everything else if time is tight. Save Dilli Haat for the day before flying out — it doubles as the perfect last-stop souvenir shop.

# The Quieter Places Most Skip

When you have done the main monuments and want something else — these are the places that locals love and tourists rarely find.

## Sunder Nursery

MUGHAL GARDEN · RESTORED

ENTRY **200 INR foreigners** TIME **90 min** BEST HOUR **7–9 a.m. or 4–6 p.m.**

A 90-acre 16th-century Mughal garden complex restored by Aga Khan Trust over 12 years and opened to the public in 2018. Six Mughal monuments scattered in immaculate landscape design. Across the road from Humayun's Tomb but visited by 5% of the foot traffic. Possibly Delhi's most peaceful place.

## Nizamuddin Dargah

SUFİ SHRINE · 14TH C.

ENTRY **Free (donations welcome)** TIME **60–90 min** BEST HOUR **Thursday qawwali (~7:30 p.m.)**

DRESS CODE **Modest, head covered, shoes off**

The tomb of 14th-century Sufi saint Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya. Working shrine — pilgrims arrive constantly. On Thursday evenings, qawwali (devotional Sufi music) performances. The walk into the dargah through Nizamuddin Basti's narrow lanes is itself an experience. Photography sensitive — ask first.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Visit with respect — this is a place of worship, not a sight. A 100–200 INR donation at the shrine is appropriate. Eat at Karim's Nizamuddin (newer branch of the Old Delhi original) afterward.



## Akshardham Temple

HINDU TEMPLE COMPLEX · 2005

ENTRY **Free (exhibits 220 INR)** TIME **3 hours** CLOSED **Mondays**

NOTE **No phones or cameras allowed inside**

A modern temple built using traditional techniques — 234 carved pillars, 9 ornate domes, 20,000 deity sculptures. The world's largest Hindu temple complex by Guinness. Polarizing — some find it spectacular, some find it sanitized. Worth visiting once for the architectural scale alone. Strict security: leave all electronics in the locker.

## Connaught Place Central Park

URBAN PARK · FREE

ENTRY **Free** TIME **30 min** BEST HOUR **Late afternoon**

The circular park at the heart of Connaught Place. A 90-foot Indian flag flies in the center. Locals come for chai and conversation. Decent toilets, free WiFi (slow), shaded benches. Useful as a meeting point or break between Connaught Place errands. Janpath market (Tibetan crafts, silver jewelry) is a 3-minute walk.

# Eating Through Delhi

Delhi has the deepest food culture of any Indian city — Mughal, Punjabi, refugee, regional, modern. This is a curated short list, not a complete one. We have eaten everywhere we recommend.

## Street Food — The Six You Must Try

| DISH                        | WHERE                                                                                           | COST                   |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Chole Bhature               | Sita Ram Diwan Chand (Paharganj) or Nagpal Chole (Kamla Nagar). The definitive Delhi breakfast. | 80–150 INR             |
| Paratha (stuffed flatbread) | Paranthe Wali Gali, Chandni Chowk. 300-year-old lane dedicated to one thing.                    | 60–150 INR each        |
| Dahi Bhalla Papdi Chaat     | Bengali Sweet House (CP) or Lajpat Nagar stalls.                                                | 60–120 INR             |
| Pani Puri / Gol Gappe       | Any clean street stall. Vendor fills them one by one — eat immediately.                         | 30–50 INR for 6 pieces |
| Nihari (slow-cooked stew)   | Kallu Nihari, Matia Mahal (Old Delhi). Morning only — sold out by 11 a.m.                       | 200–350 INR            |
| Daulat Ki Chaat             | Old Delhi only, winter months only (Dec–Feb). A foam-like cream dessert. Magical.               | 80–120 INR             |

## Restaurants Worth Detouring For

|                              |                                                                                              |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| KARIM'S (JAMA MASJID)        | Mughlai since 1913. Korma, kebabs, biryani. 500–900 INR. Cash preferred.                     |
| INDIAN ACCENT (LODHI)        | Modern Indian fine dining. Tasting menu. Book 2 weeks ahead. 4,000–7,000 INR.                |
| BUKHARA (ITC MAURYA)         | North Indian tandoor. Dal Bukhara is the dish of a lifetime. 3,500–6,000 INR. Reserve ahead. |
| MOTI MAHAL (DARYAGANJ)       | Claimed inventor of butter chicken and dal makhani. 800–1,500 INR. Old Delhi.                |
| SAGAR RATNA (DEFENCE COLONY) | South Indian standby — dosa, idli, sambar. 300–500 INR. Vegetarian.                          |
| YETI (HAUZ KHAS)             | Tibetan/Nepali comfort food. Thukpa, momos. 600–1,000 INR.                                   |

**SODABOTTLEOPENER** **W** Parsi-Iranian café-style. Berry pulao, dhansak. 800–1,400 INR.  
(KHAN MARKET)

**THE BIG CHILL** Italian comfort. Best tiramisu in Delhi. 800–1,400 INR. Cash-only.  
(KHAN / HAUZ  
KHAS)

**ALL AMERICAN** Breakfast all day. The morning Delhi traveler's haven. 400–700 INR.  
**DINER (INDIA**  
**HABITAT CENTRE)**

## Where To Be Cautious

Street food at major monuments (Red Fort gates, India Gate vendors) tends to use lower-quality water and ingredients than market street food. Eat where Indians eat. The signal: **queues of locals, visible cooking, high turnover**. An empty restaurant is a warning sign — food has been sitting. A crowded stall with three people cooking and ten people queuing is your friend.

### THE WATER RULE (WORTH REPEATING)

Sealed bottled water only. Always check the seal — squeeze the cap to confirm it clicks. Some vendors refill bottles with tap water and reseal poorly. Ice from a quality restaurant is fine (machine-made from purified water). Ice from a street stall is tap water. Brushing teeth with bottled water for your first week. After that, most travelers transition to tap water for brushing without issues.

# Eating Strategy For The Week

## DAYS 1-2 — BE CONSERVATIVE

Eat at your hotel restaurant or at sit-down restaurants we have named above. Avoid street food entirely. Your gut is still adjusting. Drink only sealed water. Carry ORS sachets in your day bag — buy at any pharmacy for 20 INR each.

## DAYS 3-4 — START EXPLORING

Try one street food item at a busy, established stall (Paranthe Wali Gali, Bengali Sweet House). Continue otherwise eating at quality restaurants. By now your system has adjusted to local microbiota.

## DAYS 5+ — GO WIDER

Street food walks, late dinners at family-run places, regional cuisine experiments. Most travelers reach this comfort by day five. Trust the busy-place rule and you will be fine.

# The Indian Restaurant Vocabulary You Need

|                          |                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| VEG / NON-VEG            | Vegetarian / Non-vegetarian. Indian restaurants are strictly divided into these categories.                                               |
| JAIN FOOD                | Vegetarian without onion, garlic, or root vegetables. Some restaurants serve "Jain" variants on request.                                  |
| THALI                    | A platter with rice, dal, two vegetables, roti, papad, pickle, dessert. Best value in Indian cuisine — 150–400 INR for unlimited refills. |
| LESS SPICY / "PHYAAR SE" | "Mildly spiced" — but still spicier than European mild. Order one level milder than instinct.                                             |
| TANDOORI                 | Cooked in a clay tandoor oven. Lower oil, smokier flavor. Generally safer for sensitive stomachs.                                         |
| CURD / LASSI             | Yogurt-based drinks/condiments. Excellent for cooling spice. Sweet lassi after spicy meal is heaven.                                      |
| ROTI VS NAAN VS PARATHA  | Roti: unleavened, healthier. Naan: leavened, soft. Paratha: layered, often stuffed.                                                       |
| PANEER                   | Fresh Indian cheese. Vegetarian. The Indian "meat substitute" for vegetarian dishes.                                                      |

## What German Travelers Often Get Wrong

- **Ordering "spicy" expecting "Indian restaurant in Berlin" level.** Indian spicy in India means actually-spicy. Order "less spicy" your first week.
- **Avoiding curd because of food safety fears.** Curd is the safest dairy product in India — it's fermented. It is literally the antidote to digestive issues.
- **Thinking vegetarian means sparse choices.** Indian vegetarian cuisine is the deepest, oldest vegetarian food tradition on earth. You will eat better vegetarian here than anywhere.
- **Eating only "Indian food."** Delhi has world-class Italian, Lebanese, Vietnamese, and Japanese. After day six, give your palate a break.



PART FOUR · THE MOUNTAINS

*540 kilometers north, the  
country  
becomes a different country.*



# Delhi → Manali — The Night Bus

This is how every traveler does it. Twelve hours of sleeper bus from the Delhi plains into the Himalayan foothills. The journey is part of the trip.

|          |              |               |                   |
|----------|--------------|---------------|-------------------|
| 540 km   | 12–14h       | 2,050m        | 2,200 INR         |
| DISTANCE | JOURNEY TIME | ALTITUDE GAIN | RECOMMENDED CLASS |

## Choosing The Bus — The Honest Operator Guide

Many operators run this route. Quality varies enormously. Based on extensive testing, here is the operator hierarchy:

| OPERATOR                     | CLASS       | FARE            | HONEST NOTES                                                                      |
|------------------------------|-------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ZingBus Premium / Max        | AC Sleeper  | 1,800–2,200 INR | Best on this route. Welcome kit, meals included, hygiene kit, premium suspension. |
| HRTC Volvo (Government)      | AC Sleeper  | 1,500–1,800 INR | Reliable, well-maintained, slightly older fleet. Book on hrtcuk.com.              |
| Himachal Tourism Volvo       | AC Sleeper  | 1,400–1,700 INR | Official tourism dept. Decent.                                                    |
| Patel Tours / Manali Travels | AC Sleeper  | 1,200–1,600 INR | Private operators. Quality varies — check redBus ratings before booking.          |
| Standard non-AC sleeper      | Sleeper Bus | 800–1,200 INR   | Cold in winter, hot in summer. Skip unless on tight budget.                       |

Our recommendation: **ZingBus Max**. The 200-INR difference over standard Volvo buys: a hot meal, a welcome kit (eye mask, ear plugs, water, snack, hygiene kit), better quality berths, and noticeably better drivers. For one overnight per direction, the upgrade is worth it.

## How To Book

1

### Use redBus.in Or MakeMyTrip

Both show all operators, real-time seat availability with photos of the actual bus interior, and verified reviews. Filter by "AC Sleeper" + "Volvo." Book at least 3–5 days in advance during peak season (May–September).

2

### Choose The Right Seat

Single berths (along the wall) are wider and more private than double-shared berths. Lower berths are easier to enter. Avoid the very last row (next to the engine — noisy and hot). Berths 3–10 are the sweet spot.

3

### Confirm Departure Point

99% of Delhi → Manali buses depart from **ISBT Kashmiri Gate**. Some pickup from Majnu Ka Tila (Tibetan colony) and Rajiv Chowk. Confirm the exact terminal at booking and arrive 45 minutes early.

4

### Bus Ticket Goes To Your Phone + Email

Save both as offline accessible. The operator may ask for ID at boarding — passport works.



## What To Pack For The Bus

The bus has a luggage hold underneath. Your main suitcase goes there. Bring a separate cabin bag with everything you will need for 13 hours:

- **Warm layer.** Fleece, hoodie, or light down jacket. Mountains get cold at night even in summer. The bus AC also gets aggressive.
- **2-liter water bottle.** The bus stops twice but bring your own water for in-between.
- **Snacks.** Biscuits, chips, dried fruit, chocolate. The bus dinner is hot but light.
- **Phone + power bank + cable.** Berths have USB charging but it can be intermittent.
- **Eye mask + ear plugs.** If you didn't get them in the welcome kit.
- **Toilet paper / tissues.** The dhabas (roadside restaurants) have basic toilets.
- **Hand sanitizer.** Use after every stop.
- **Basic medicines.** Anti-nausea (Avomine or Meclizine) if you get motion sick. Take BEFORE departure, not when you start feeling ill. Painkillers, anti-diarrhea tablets just in case.
- **Passport.** In your inner pocket, not the cabin bag.
- **Cash.** Small notes for dhaba meals and chai.

## The Journey, Hour By Hour

|               |                                                                                                                                         |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 8:30–9:00 PM  | Boarding at ISBT Kashmiri Gate. Confirm your berth number, stow main luggage in the hold.                                               |
| 9:30 PM       | Departure. Welcome kit handed out. Bus exits Delhi via the Yamuna Expressway / NH-44.                                                   |
| 10:30 PM      | Hot dinner served onboard (premium operators only). Rice, dal, paneer, roti. Lights dim after dinner.                                   |
| 1:00 AM       | First dhaba stop near Murthal or Karnal. 20-minute break. Use the toilet, stretch.                                                      |
| 3:30 AM       | Pass Chandigarh. Most passengers asleep. Bus exits the Punjab plains, begins the climb.                                                 |
| 5:00 AM       | Second dhaba stop near Bilaspur or Mandi. 20-minute break. Chai. The mountains become visible.                                          |
| 6:30 AM       | First Himalayan light. The bus rounds curves with views down to the Beas River. This is the best part of the journey — try to be awake. |
| 7:30 AM       | Kullu town passed. Manali is 40 km of mountain road away.                                                                               |
| 8:30–10:00 AM | Arrival at Manali Bus Stand. Exit, find your prearranged taxi or walk to your hotel (if close).                                         |

## The Last Two Hours — Motion Sickness Warning

The final stretch from Mandi to Manali involves continuous switchback turns up the Beas Valley. Even non-prone travelers can get carsick. Take an anti-nausea tablet 30 minutes before this stretch (around 6 a.m.). Look out the window at the horizon line, not at your phone. Sip ginger tea at the morning dhaba stop.

### MOUNTAIN ROAD REALITY

Mountain roads in Himachal are well-maintained but they are mountain roads. Delays from rockfall or weather happen. A 12-hour journey occasionally becomes 14–15. This is normal. Pack for the longer scenario. The driver knows what he is doing — Indian mountain drivers are professionals on these routes for decades.

### FIRST ARRIVAL IN MANALI

You will arrive tired, slightly disoriented, possibly cold. Do not negotiate with taxi drivers at the bus stand — they will overcharge. Walk to your hotel if it is close (Old Manali is a 20-minute walk from the bus stand) or use the Ola app. Check in, shower, eat breakfast at the hotel, then rest until lunch. Day-of-arrival sightseeing in Manali is a mistake.

# Arriving In Manali

*You step off the bus at 9 a.m. into thin mountain air, pine smell, and a small town carved into a valley. Here is how the first day should unfold — slowly.*



THE MANALI VALLEY · last light hitting the Pir Panjal peaks · view from Old Manali

## The Bus Stand And What To Do First

The main Manali bus stand sits in the lower part of New Manali, on Mall Road. It is small, single-platform, and chaotic for ten minutes after each bus arrives. Taxi drivers will surround you. Do not negotiate at the bus stand. The fair rate to any hotel within 3 km is 200–400 INR; drivers there will quote 800–1,200 INR.

Three better options:

- **Walk.** If your hotel is in Old Manali or near Mall Road, it is a 15–25 minute walk. Cool mountain air, no negotiation, immediate immersion. Your suitcase has wheels.
- **Use Ola.** Ola operates in Manali and shows real prices. Less consistent than in Delhi but works most days. Wait time 5–10 minutes.

- **Hotel pickup.** Most mid-range hotels offer free or nominal-cost (200 INR) pickup from the bus stand. Arrange this when booking. The driver waits with a paper sign.

## First-Day Approach

### A GENTLE FIRST DAY

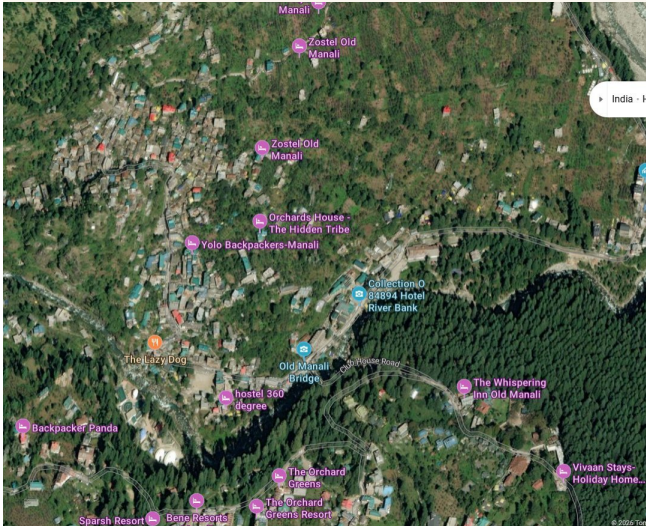
Check in. Shower. Have a proper breakfast at the hotel or a nearby café. Walk along the Beas River for an hour — it is two minutes from anywhere in central Manali. Take a long lunch. Sleep if you want. Spend the late afternoon walking Mall Road or Old Manali bazaar. Eat early. Sleep deep. Day-of-arrival sightseeing is the most common Manali mistake.

### ALTITUDE NOTE

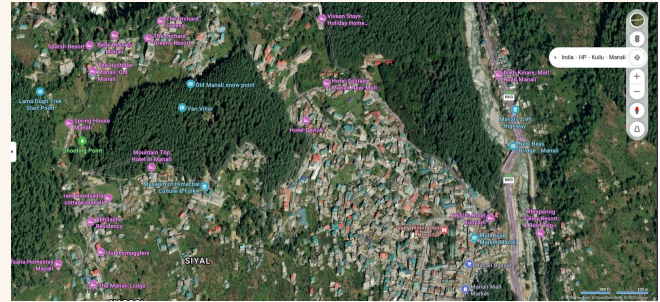
Manali sits at 2,050 meters. You may feel mild breathlessness, a slight headache, slower pace. This is your body adjusting and usually passes within 24 hours. Drink 3+ liters of water on Day 1. Skip alcohol your first night. If symptoms persist past 48 hours or worsen significantly, see a doctor — altitude sickness is rare at this elevation but possible. Sissu (Day 6) is at 3,100m — wait until you are fully acclimatized.

# Where To Sleep In Manali

Manali splits into four neighborhoods, each with a distinct feel. Pick based on what you want — café-and-river atmosphere, central convenience, or hot-springs quiet.



OLD MANALI · narrow lanes, riverside cafés, the Beas across a wooden bridge



MALL ROAD / NEW MANALI · central, services, bus stand

## Old Manali — Our First Recommendation

Across the Beas River from New Manali via the Old Manali Bridge. Narrow lanes lined with cafés, hostels, slow guesthouses, and apple orchards. The café culture is the heart of Manali for most travelers. Five-minute walk to the river. Twenty-minute walk back to Mall Road for services.

### BOUTIQUE · OLD MANALI

#### Apple Country Resort

3,500–6,500 INR / night · [MakeMyTrip](#) or [direct booking](#)

Wooden cottages set in an apple orchard. Heater in every room (essential for the cold months). Excellent breakfast. Quieter than the central Old Manali strip — 10-minute walk to cafés. Best mid-range stay in Manali for our money.



HOSTEL • OLD MANALI

## Zostel Old Manali

600–1,500 INR / night • [zostel.com](https://www.zostel.com)

Best-run hostel chain in India. Dorms and private rooms. Lively communal area, fast WiFi, secure lockers. Best for solo travelers wanting to meet others. Book direct on their site for slightly cheaper rates.

## New Manali / Mall Road — For Convenience

The town center. Closer to the bus stand, ATMs, pharmacies, shops, and restaurants. More built-up, less character than Old Manali, but useful as a base if you want everything within walking distance.

MID-RANGE • MALL ROAD

## Hotel Snow View

2,500–4,500 INR / night • [MakeMyTrip](https://www.makemytrip.com) or [Booking.com](https://www.booking.com)

The Mall Road landmark hotel. Slightly dated, but clean, central, and reliable. Mountain views from rear-facing rooms only — ask specifically. Walk-up to all Mall Road shops.

## Vashisht — For Hot Springs & Quiet

A 4-km drive from Mall Road, on the opposite (eastern) side of the Beas River. Smaller, older, with the famous Vashisht Temple and natural hot sulphur springs. Quieter than Old Manali, more locally Himachali in feel. Best for travelers wanting calm and a hot bath.

MID-RANGE • VASHISHT

## Negi's Hilltop Resort

3,000–5,500 INR / night • [Booking.com](https://www.booking.com)

Sits above Vashisht village with full valley views. Family-run for three generations. Heater rooms, decent restaurant. Solo female travelers report feeling safer here than in livelier areas.

## Solang Or Higher — For Adventure Travelers

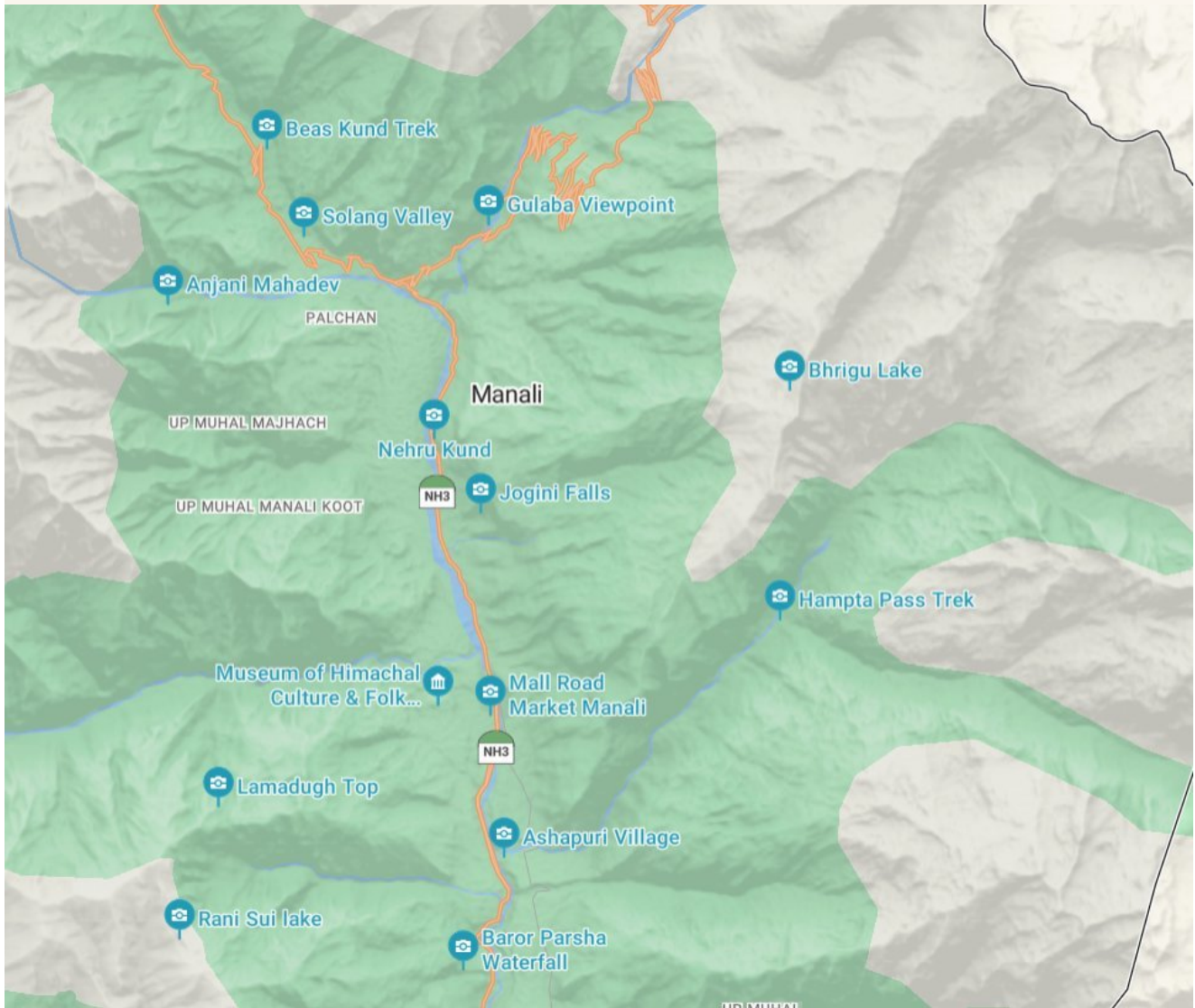
Stays in Solang Valley (14 km from Mall Road) are only worth it if you are doing serious skiing or paragliding for 3+ days. Otherwise stay in Old Manali and visit Solang on a day trip.

#### BOOKING STRATEGY FOR MANALI

Book firmly for your first two nights. Leave subsequent nights flexible — Manali hotels rarely fill up except on Indian holiday weekends (Diwali, Christmas, New Year, summer break). Walking in is normal in shoulder season and often gets you a discount. **Always confirm whether the room has a heater** — non-negotiable from October through March.

# The Places That Matter

Manali is small. Most places are within 30 minutes of each other. Three days lets you explore unhurried. Below are the places we think are worth your time – and a few we tell people to skip.



MANALI REGION · Solang Valley north, Hampta Pass east, Mall Road center · most stops within 25 km



## Hadimba Temple · Dhungri

1553 · PAGODA TEMPLE

ENTRY **Free** TIME **45–60 min** BEST HOUR **Early morning or just before sunset**

DISTANCE FROM MALL ROAD **2 km uphill** HOW TO REACH **15-min walk uphill, or 80–150 INR auto / taxi**

A 470-year-old wooden pagoda temple in the middle of a cedar forest, dedicated to Hadimba — wife of the Pandava warrior Bhima in the Mahabharata. Built around a natural cave where Hadimba meditated. The carved wooden doors, the dark stone interior, and the surrounding deodar grove create an atmosphere unlike any other temple in India. Locals come at dusk; tourists at midday. We strongly recommend the dusk version.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

The temple grounds host yak rides, costume photographs, and souvenir stalls — these are touristy but not unpleasant. The Ghatotkach Temple (Hadimba's son) is 100 meters further uphill — quieter, beautiful, almost unvisited.

## Manu Temple · Old Manali

STONE TEMPLE · ANCIENT

ENTRY **Free** TIME **30–45 min** BEST HOUR **Morning**

LOCATION **Top of Old Manali, walk uphill from the bridge**

Dedicated to Sage Manu — the figure who Hindu cosmology says created humanity. Said to be the only Manu temple in India. The walk uphill through Old Manali's apple orchards is the experience as much as the temple itself. Modest, white-painted, atmospheric. Pair this with breakfast at one of Old Manali's cafés before heading up.

### BEYONDTAJ TIP

The lanes around Manu Temple are quieter than the main Old Manali strip. Wander them. You will see Himachali houses with slate roofs, apple trees in courtyards, and locals carrying baskets of vegetables uphill.

## Vashisht Temple & Hot Springs

4,000-YEAR-OLD TEMPLE

**ENTRY** Free (temple). 50 INR (public springs). 200 INR (private bath). **TIME** 60–90 min

**DISTANCE** 3 km east of Mall Road, across the river **HOW TO REACH** 200–300 INR auto from Mall Road

Dedicated to Sage Vashisht — guru of Lord Rama. The wooden carvings on the temple facade are 450+ years old and exquisite. The natural hot sulphur springs adjacent are working baths — separate for men and women. The water is genuinely healing (sulphur, magnesium), genuinely hot (40–45°C), and genuinely public. The private bathing rooms are cleaner if you prefer privacy.

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### BEYONDTAJ TIP

*Bring your own small towel and a change of clothes. Public baths have basic facilities. Foreigners are welcome but you will be the only one — expect curious looks (kind, not hostile). For comfort, the private baths are worth the 200 INR.*

## More Places (continued)

### The Beas River Banks

RIVER · FREE

ENTRY **Free** TIME **As long as you want** BEST HOUR **7 a.m. or just before sunset**

The single most under-recommended thing to do in Manali. Walk down from Old Manali Bridge to the rocky riverbank. Sit on the rocks. Put your feet in (ice-cold glacial water — for 30 seconds maximum). Listen. There is nothing to do here — that is the point. Most travelers report this as the moment Manali made sense to them. Free, possible at any hour, requires nothing.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

*Bring a small thermos of chai. A book. Sit for an hour. Do not look at your phone. The mountains and the river will do the work.*

### Van Vihar National Park

FOREST PARK · OFF MALL ROAD

ENTRY **50 INR (foreigners)** TIME **45–60 min** OPEN **9 a.m.–8 p.m. (summer)**

A wooded urban park at the edge of Mall Road. Cedar trees, walking paths, a small pond with paddle boats, benches, and clean toilets. Locals come here to escape the Mall Road crowds. Great for an unstructured hour. The cedar grove feels much older than it is.

### Tibetan Monastery · Gadhan Thekchhokling Gompa

BUDDHIST · 1969

ENTRY **Free** TIME **30 min** LOCATION **Near Mall Road, 5-min walk south**

Founded by Tibetan refugees who settled in Manali after 1959. Modest, working monastery — monks chant in the early morning. Beautiful prayer wheels around the courtyard. The adjacent Tibetan handicraft shops sell genuine pieces (thangkas, prayer flags, singing bowls). Bargain gently but not aggressively — these are refugees running small enterprises.

## Mall Road & Manali Bazaar

MAIN STREET · FREE

ENTRY **Free**    TIME **2–3 hours casual**    BEST HOUR **5–8 p.m.**

Pedestrian-only main shopping street. Buy: Himachali woollen caps (200–400 INR), Pashmina shawls (real ones 4,000+ INR, fakes 500 INR — ask to burn-test a thread), apple jams and dried apricots, local honey, Tibetan jewellery. Bargain on everything that does not have a fixed price tag. Evening atmosphere is excellent — busking musicians, food stalls, families walking.

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### BEYONDTAJ TIP

*Real Pashmina vs fake: the burn test. A single thread of real Pashmina burns to ash and smells like hair (it is wool). Fake Pashmina (acrylic) melts into a bead and smells like plastic. Honest shopkeepers will let you test before buying. Avoid the "70% off!" stalls — the originals were never 100% to begin with.*

## Two More You Should See



VASHISHT SIDE · a Himachali woman, a cow, daily mountain life



MALL ROAD BAZAAR · shops, signs, the deodar-forested ridge above

### Museum Of Himachal Culture & Folk Art

MUSEUM · HADIMBA ROAD

ENTRY **50 INR** TIME **45 min** CLOSED **Sundays**

Tiny family-run museum showing 200 years of Kullu and Lahaul material culture — traditional dress, musical instruments, agricultural tools, household items, jewellery, religious masks. Underrated and quiet. Best context-builder before exploring rural Himachal.

### Naggar Castle & Roerich Art Gallery

15TH C. WOODEN CASTLE

ENTRY **50 INR** TIME **2–3 hours total** DISTANCE **22 km south of Manali (45 min drive)**

HOW TO REACH **Half-day taxi from Manali — 1,500–2,000 INR round trip**

A 15th-century wood-and-stone palace built without nails, perched on a ridge above the Beas Valley. Now operated as a heritage hotel and museum. The Nicholas Roerich Art Gallery is in the same village — the Russian painter spent his final 19 years here painting the Himalayas. His mountain canvases are extraordinary. Worth the half-day if you have a flexible itinerary.

#### BEYONDTAJ TIP

Combine Naggar with lunch at the castle's heritage restaurant. The Beas Valley views are best from the castle terrace. Rivulet rafting in the Beas (April–June, 800–1,500 INR per person) is available 10 km below Naggar.

# Building Your Manali Days

## A SLOW MANALI DAY — OLD TOWN FOCUS

**Morning:** Walk to Manu Temple through Old Manali's lanes. **Late morning:** Breakfast at Drifters or Café 1947. **Afternoon:** Beas River walk and rocks. **Late afternoon:** Hadimba Temple at golden hour. **Evening:** Tibetan dinner at a Mall Road café. Total walking: 8–10 km. Total cost ex-meals: 100 INR autos.

## A SLOW MANALI DAY — VASHISHT FOCUS

**Morning:** Auto to Vashisht. Walk the village. **Late morning:** Hot springs bath. **Lunch:** Local thali at a Vashisht restaurant. **Afternoon:** Walk back via the Beas riverbank. **Evening:** Café in Old Manali, journal time. Total walking: 6–8 km. Total cost ex-meals: 500 INR (auto + baths).

## WHAT TO SKIP IN MANALI

**Manali Club House.** A small entertainment complex with paid mini-golf, video games, etc. — built for Indian families, dated, skippable for foreign travelers. **Aerial rope adventures at Solang.** If you want adventure, take paragliding or skiing — see next pages. The rope adventure courses are overpriced for what they are. **Tibetan Carpet "factories"** outside Mall Road — these are sales operations, not factories. Buy from monastery shops instead.

# Solang Valley & Jogini Falls

*If you do one full day outside central Manali (other than Sissu), make it this one. Solang Valley sits at 2,560m and is the closest place to experience real Himalayan landscape. Jogini Falls is a 2-hour trek from Vashisht.*

## Solang Valley

|              |                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DISTANCE     | 14 km north of Manali Mall Road. ~40 minute drive.                                                                                     |
| HOW TO REACH | Shared taxi from Mall Road taxi stand (300–400 INR per person each way) or private taxi (1,500–2,500 INR round trip with 4-hour wait). |
| ENTRY        | Free to the valley. Activities priced individually.                                                                                    |
| TIME NEEDED  | Half day (4–5 hours from Manali) at minimum. Full day worth it if doing 2+ activities.                                                 |
| SNOW SEASON  | December through March. Greenery season April through November.                                                                        |

## Activities — What's Real, What's Worth It

| ACTIVITY                            | COST                               | WORTH IT?                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Paragliding (short tandem, 5 min)   | 1,800–2,500 INR                    | Yes if you have never tried it. Take from Dobhi launch point, ~10 km from Solang.              |
| Paragliding (long tandem, 15 min)   | 3,500–5,000 INR                    | Excellent. Higher launch, longer flight, valley-wide views.                                    |
| Zorbing (rolling in a giant ball)   | 500–800 INR                        | Touristy. Fun once. Five minutes.                                                              |
| Solang Ropeway                      | 750 INR                            | Yes if you don't paraglide. 1.3 km cable car to a snow viewpoint at 3,200m. Beautiful.         |
| ATV ride / Snow scooter             | 400–800 INR                        | Tourist gimmick — short loops. Skip.                                                           |
| Hot Air Balloon (tethered)          | 1,000–1,500 INR                    | Brief 12-min ride. Pleasant but not the highlight.                                             |
| Horse ride to Anjani Mahadev Temple | 500–800 INR                        | Beautiful walk option — 30 minutes uphill to a temple with a natural ice Shivalinga in winter. |
| Skiing (Dec–Feb only)               | 800–1,500 INR/hour with instructor | Real ski school for beginners. Take a half-day if conditions permit.                           |

### THE HONEST ACTIVITY STRATEGY

Pick one big activity (paragliding OR ropeway OR Anjani Mahadev walk), not three small ones. The "everything package" deals (2,000 INR for 4 activities) are usually 30 seconds of each — not worth the day. Paragliding is the standout. If you do not paraglide, the ropeway is the next best.

## Jogini Falls Trek

|             |                                                                                           |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TRAILHEAD   | Vashisht village, near the temple — 3 km from Mall Road                                   |
| TREK LENGTH | 3 km up, 3 km down. Approx. 90 minutes up, 60 minutes down.                               |
| DIFFICULTY  | Moderate. Continuous uphill but well-marked. Not suitable for travelers with knee issues. |
| BEST TIME   | Early morning (cooler) or late afternoon (golden light)                                   |



**GUIDE**

Not required — the trail is obvious. A local boy will offer to guide for 200–400 INR; useful if it's your first Himalayan trek.

A 150-foot waterfall fed by glacial melt. The trail climbs through apple orchards, then pine forest, then a final stretch over rocks to the upper pool. The lower viewpoint (about 45 minutes in) is itself rewarding if you don't want to climb the full distance. In late afternoon, a small rainbow forms in the spray.

**TREK SAFETY**

Wear proper closed shoes — sneakers are fine, sandals are not. Carry 1.5 litres of water. The last 200 meters before the falls are rocky and slippery year-round. Do not climb on rocks at the base of the falls — currents are stronger than they look.

# The Manali Café Culture

Manali has one of the most surprising café scenes in India — built by Tibetan refugees, Israeli backpackers, and Himachali entrepreneurs over forty years. Sitting in a wooden café at 2,000 metres with rain on a tin roof is genuinely one of the joys of this trip.

## Cafés & Restaurants — Old Manali Focus

|                           |                                                                                                                           |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| JOHNSON'S CAFÉ            | Continental + Indian. Their fresh trout is the dish to order. Garden seating, wood-fire pizza oven. 400–800 INR / person. |
| LA PLAGE MANALI           | French-inspired bistro. Pasta, salads, cheese plates. Excellent croissants. 500–900 INR.                                  |
| DRIFTERS INN CAFÉ         | Old Manali institution. Best banana pancakes, decent Tibetan food, big breakfast plates. 300–500 INR.                     |
| CAFÉ 1947                 | River-side outdoor seating, live music most evenings. Touristy but pleasant. 400–600 INR.                                 |
| DYLAN'S TOASTED & ROASTED | Café and bookshop. Excellent filter coffee, brownies, atmosphere. 250–450 INR.                                            |
| THE LAZY DOG LOUNGE       | Cozy, warm, fireplace. Excellent burgers and pasta. Slow service — it's a hangout. 500–800 INR.                           |
| RENAISSANCE CAFÉ          | Quiet, healthy menu. Bowls, salads, vegan options. 400–700 INR.                                                           |

## Mall Road & New Manali

|                   |                                                                                           |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CHOPSTICKS        | Best Chinese-Tibetan in Manali. Momos, thukpa, fried noodles. 350–600 INR.                |
| KHYBER RESTAURANT | North Indian, since 1978. Reliable thalis and Mughlai dishes. 400–700 INR.                |
| CAFÉ AMIGOS       | Mexican-themed but reliable across cuisines. Good for tired travel evenings. 400–700 INR. |

## Local Himachali Food — What To Order

| DISH                | WHAT IT IS                                                                                                     | WHERE                                    |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Trout               | Fresh Himalayan river trout, grilled with mountain herbs. The standout local dish.                             | Johnson's Café, La Plage                 |
| Siddu               | Steamed bread stuffed with poppy seeds, walnuts, or paneer. Eaten with ghee. Heavy, warming.                   | Local Himachali dhabas, ask specifically |
| Aktori              | Buckwheat pancake from high-altitude Lahaul valleys. Sweet or savory.                                          | Rare — Lahauli-run restaurants           |
| Madra (Kullu Madra) | Chickpea-yogurt curry, a Kullu Valley specialty.                                                               | Khyber, local thali places               |
| Babru               | Fried lentil-stuffed bread. Common breakfast.                                                                  | Roadside stalls, Mall Road early morning |
| Apple products      | Fresh apple juice, apple jam, dried apples, apple wine (locally made, legal, surprisingly good as a souvenir). | Mall Road shops                          |

### THE CAFÉ ETIQUETTE

Manali cafés operate on relaxed time. Service is slow on purpose — these are hangouts, not restaurants. Order, then settle in for an hour. WiFi is generally good (occasionally drops). Tipping 10% on the bill is appreciated but not expected. Most cafés take card or UPI. Always carry some cash as backup.

# Atal Tunnel, Sissu & Keylong

A single day takes you under a mountain through the world's longest highway tunnel and out into a different valley — Lahaul. The landscape on the other side is genuinely otherworldly: dry, treeless, vast.



SISSU · after the tunnel · the Lahaul Valley · 3,100 metres

**9.02 km**

ATAL TUNNEL

**3,100m**

SISSU ALTITUDE

**65 km**

FROM MANALI

**2,500+**

INR DAY TRIP

## The Plan

This is the one day in your trip with a slightly fixed shape — not because of a schedule, but because you must return to Manali before dark (mountain roads, no Uber, sunset early). Most people leave Manali around 7:30 a.m. and are back by 7 p.m. — eleven hours total, including 2.5 hours of driving each way.

## How To Reach — Critically Important

### DO NOT TAKE THE PUBLIC BUS

Local buses exist to Keylong but are unreliable, crowded, and leave you stranded inside the Lahaul Valley without onward transport. There is **no Uber or Ola beyond the Atal Tunnel**. Once you exit the tunnel, the only return is what you arrived in.

Book a private taxi for the day through your hotel or a local agency. Negotiate the rate in advance — confirm what is included (waiting time, multiple stops, tunnel toll, return).

| VEHICLE                             | FAIR RATE       | NOTES                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sedan (Maruti Dzire) for 2–3 people | 2,500–3,500 INR | Adequate. Cheapest option.                                                      |
| SUV (Innova) for 4+ people          | 3,500–4,500 INR | More comfortable. Better suspension for the rough sections beyond Sissu.        |
| Local Himachali driver-owner        | 3,000–4,000 INR | The drivers know the road and stops. Often the best experience. Ask your hotel. |

### TAXI SCAM WARNING

Some drivers quote 6,000–8,000 INR for this route. The real price is 2,500–4,000 INR. If you book at the bus stand or via random street drivers, you will overpay. Hotel reception or established agencies are the safer bet. Pay half upfront, half on return.

## The Suggested Stops

- **Atal Tunnel entry — South Portal.** Stop for photos at the south portal. The drive through the tunnel takes 15 minutes. Speed limit 80 km/h. Phones lose signal entirely inside.
- **Sissu Lake.** Once you exit the tunnel, drive ~6 km to Sissu Lake — a glacial pool fed by waterfall, almost no tourists, surrounded by snow peaks. Sit here for 30 minutes. The silence is the experience.
- **Sissu Waterfall & Zipline.** Walk 10 minutes from the lake to the falls. A community-run zipline (400–600 INR) crosses the valley above them. Surprisingly safe, surprisingly fun.
- **Sissu village.** Walk through the stone-and-wood Lahauli houses. The Buddhist culture is visible — prayer flags, mani walls, painted gates. Be respectful with photography; ask first.
- **Lunch at a Sissu dhaba.** Simple, hot, honest — dal, rice, roti for 150–250 INR. The food tastes better at altitude.

- **Keylong (optional).** 30 km further if your driver agrees and the day allows. The Lahaul district headquarters. The Kardang Monastery sits on a cliff opposite Keylong — 30-min walk uphill from the parking, well worth it.
- **Return through the tunnel.** Aim to re-enter the tunnel southward by 5 p.m. Sunset on the Manali side is beautiful as you descend.

# The Return Journey

*Heading back to Delhi for your departure flight. Same bus route in reverse, but a different feeling. You are no longer arriving in India — you are leaving with it.*

## Last Hours In Manali

On the day of your bus departure, check out by noon (most hotels offer late check-out until 2 p.m. on request). Leave your bag at the hotel — they will store it for free. Use the day for things you didn't get to: a final café in Old Manali, a walk along the Beas, a last visit to Hadimba Temple, picking up Himachali apple wine or honey as gifts from Mall Road shops.

Aim to arrive at Manali bus stand 30 minutes before departure (typically 5–7 p.m. for buses arriving in Delhi the next morning). Your return ticket should be booked the same way as your outbound — redBus or MakeMyTrip, same operator class.

## Arriving Back In Delhi

You will arrive at ISBT Kashmiri Gate at approximately 6–9 a.m. Book an Uber immediately from the bus stand. If your flight is the same day:

- **Flights before 2 p.m.:** Tight. Skip Delhi entirely — head directly to the airport, use the lounge or a day-use airport hotel (Holiday Inn Express Aerocity offers 6-hour day-use bookings for ~2,500 INR).
- **Flights between 2 and 8 p.m.:** Comfortable. Have a proper breakfast in Connaught Place, shop at Janpath or Dilli Haat for last souvenirs, leave for the airport 4 hours before flight.
- **Evening or late-night flights:** Spacious. A South Delhi day-use hotel for shower and rest, then airport.

## Airport Departure

Delhi IGI requires a passport check before you can enter the terminal building — show your printed ETA or e-visa email. Allow 3 hours minimum for international flights. Security can be slow during peak hours (5–9 a.m., 5–9 p.m.).

- **Customs declaration.** Generally not needed for tourists. If you bought antiques over 100 years old, you may need an export certificate — buy only from reputable shops with paperwork.

- **Duty-free.** Indian duty-free has competitive prices on tea, single-malt whisky, and Indian sweets. Mediocre on perfumes and electronics — buy those at home.
- **Lounge access.** If your credit card has Priority Pass or you have a relevant Indian card, the Plaza Premium Lounge at T3 is excellent (separate entry for India lounge vs international lounge).

#### ONE LAST THING

The final stretch of your trip will pass faster than the rest. India will not feel the same as it did on Day 1. Make space for that. Eat one last Indian meal at the airport food court (Saravanaa Bhavan for South Indian, or Café Coffee Day for chai). Drink one last lassi. Watch India through the window as the plane lifts. You are taking more than you arrived with.



# Do's & Don'ts That Actually Matter

Most travel guides hedge every recommendation. This page does not. These are the rules that, followed, smooth your trip. Ignored, they cause real problems.

## The Do's

|                                       |                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DRINK SEALED WATER ONLY               | Bisleri, Kinley, Aquafina. Check the seal clicks. Never tap, never ice in suspect places. This single habit prevents 90% of stomach issues.                          |
| USE UBER OR OLA IN CITIES             | Fixed price, GPS-tracked, no negotiation, digital receipt. Almost always cheaper than negotiated taxis.                                                              |
| BARGAIN AT OPEN MARKETS               | Start at 40–50% of asking price. It is expected and nobody is offended. Bargaining is conversation, not confrontation.                                               |
| REMOVE SHOES AT TEMPLES               | Always. Some temples have shoe-keepers (5–10 INR). Bring socks for hot stone floors in summer.                                                                       |
| DRESS MODESTLY AT RELIGIOUS SITES     | Cover shoulders and knees. Carry a scarf in your day bag for both temples and unexpected mosque visits.                                                              |
| TRUST YOUR HOTEL                      | Hotel staff are your best local resource. Ask them anything before asking a stranger on the street — they have less reason to mislead you.                           |
| EAT AT BUSY RESTAURANTS               | High turnover = fresh food. An empty restaurant in India is a warning. A queue is a green light.                                                                     |
| LEARN FIVE HINDI WORDS                | Namaste (hello), Dhanyavaad (thank you), Kitna? (how much?), Nahin (no), Bhai/Didi (brother/sister, used to address people respectfully). Locals warm to any effort. |
| CARRY SMALL CHANGE                    | 10, 20, 50, and 100 INR notes in a separate pocket. Vendors often can't break large bills.                                                                           |
| TAKE THE LOCAL TRAIN OR BUS ONCE      | Not as a logistics choice — as an experience. Even one 30-minute Delhi Metro ride teaches you more about Delhi than any monument.                                    |
| USE GOOGLE MAPS WITH OFFLINE DOWNLOAD | Download Delhi + Manali offline maps before arrival. Saves data, works without signal.                                                                               |
| TAKE A DAY TO DO NOTHING              | India is high-stimulus. The travelers who plan rest days enjoy the trip more than those who don't.                                                                   |

## The Don'ts

### DON'T GIVE MONEY TO BEGGARS

Especially children. Most organized begging is run by adults who take the money — your INR feeds a system, not the child. If you want to help India, donate to a registered NGO (Goonj, CRY, Smile Foundation).

### DON'T ACCEPT FOOD OR DRINK FROM STRANGERS

On trains or buses. Drugging-and-robbing tourists, while rare, does happen. Buy your own food.

### DON'T PAY ANYONE WHO APPROACHED YOU

If you did not initiate the interaction — the "guide" who started explaining the monument, the "police" who asked for your passport, the "businessman" with the gem deal — do not pay for the outcome.

### DON'T PHOTOGRAPH MILITARY INSTALLATIONS

Airports, bridges, dams, defense areas — off limits. The signs are there. Penalties are serious.

### DON'T PHOTOGRAPH PEOPLE WITHOUT ASKING

Especially women, children, tribal communities, and religious figures. Ask first — most say yes with a smile. Some will ask 50–100 INR as a model fee — that's fair.

### DON'T FLASH EXPENSIVE ELECTRONICS

Keep your phone in your front pocket in crowded markets. Use a zipped bag. Snatching from open bags happens.

### DON'T BOOK LOCAL TAXIS WITHOUT CONFIRMING PRICE

Always agree on the rate and what is included (waiting time, toll, return) before getting in. After the fact is too late.

### DON'T DISPLAY AFFECTION IN PUBLIC

Hugging is fine. Kissing in public is socially awkward and in some areas legally questionable. Save it for hotels.

### DON'T WEAR SHOES INSIDE HOMES

If you are invited into a home, shoes off at the entrance. Always.

### DON'T EAT WITH YOUR LEFT HAND

In traditional contexts, the left hand is unclean. Use the right hand or utensils. Modern urban contexts are relaxed about this; rural and traditional ones are not.

### DON'T DRINK TAP WATER TO TAKE A PILL

Worth repeating. Always sealed bottled water — even for brushing teeth your first week.

### DON'T DISMISS INDIA BECAUSE IT'S MESSY

India is loud, chaotic, intense, extraordinary. The disorder is part of the texture. Travelers who fight it lose. Those who lean in find magic.

## Cultural Etiquette Worth Knowing

- **The head wobble.** The Indian head-bob — somewhere between a yes and a maybe — is real and means "OK, understood, I am listening." Not yes, not no. Reciprocate when appropriate.
- **"Yes" doesn't always mean yes.** Indians dislike disappointing people. "Yes, the restaurant is open" can mean "I hope so, I'm not sure." Confirm directly with Google when stakes matter.

- **Time is flexible.** "Five minutes" can mean 30. "I'm coming" can mean within the hour. This is not deception — it is a different relationship with time. Adjust your expectations downward.
- **Personal space is smaller.** Queues are looser, people stand closer, physical contact is normal. Don't take offense if a stranger asks where you are from in close range.
- **Religion is daily life.** Most Indians genuinely practice their faith. Treating temples, mosques, and gurudwaras as photo opportunities rather than sacred spaces is the single fastest way to lose local respect.

# The Scam Encyclopedia

Every one of these has happened to travelers many times. Knowing them means none of them will happen to you. The script is always the same; only the details change.

## The Big Ones

### 1. THE AIRPORT TAXI SCAM

A driver in arrivals quotes 2,000–4,000 INR for a 15-km ride. Fair price: 450–700 INR. **Solution:** Uber/Ola only, or the official Delhi Police prepaid taxi counter inside the terminal.

### 2. THE CLOSED MONUMENT SCAM

"The Red Fort is closed today for a special ceremony" — usually said by a stranger near the entrance. They offer to take you to "an alternative" — almost always a government-handicraft shop that pays commission. **Solution:** The monument is fine. Walk to the actual entrance. Verify by checking the official ASI sign.

### 3. THE FRIENDLY GUIDE SCAM

Someone follows you and "helpfully" explains the history of a monument. When you try to leave, they demand 500–2,000 INR. **Solution:** Never accept impromptu guide services. If you want a guide, hire an ASI-licensed one at the entrance — they carry official IDs.

### 4. THE GEM EXPORT BUSINESS

A "businessman" befriends you and asks if you'd be willing to carry gems or textiles to your country and "resell them duty-free" — splitting the profits. Illegal in both countries. The gems are worthless or paste. **Solution:** Walk away. Report to the tourist police if persistent.

### 5. THE RIGGED METER

Some auto meters are tampered to run fast or skip slowly. The fare comes out 3x what it should be. **Solution:** Use Uber/Ola autos (fixed price). For street autos, agree a flat fare in advance by referencing your Uber estimate.

## 6. THE FAKE POLICE

Men claim to be plain-clothes police and ask to see your passport and money — for "drug check" or "currency verification." Real police don't do this. **Solution:** Insist on going to the nearest police station. Do not hand your passport over on the street. They will disappear.

## 7. THE HOLY MAN & TILAK TRAP

Especially near temples and ghats. A man in robes blesses you, places a tilak (red mark) on your forehead, ties a thread on your wrist — then demands a large "donation," often 1,000–5,000 INR. **Solution:** Do not accept anything from strangers. Step back politely and refuse the tilak before it touches you.

## 8. THE TRAIN STATION "HELP"

At Delhi's New Delhi Railway Station or ISBT Kashmiri Gate, men claim to be government tourism officers and lead you to "the tourism office" — actually a private travel agency that overcharges for everything. **Solution:** Real Government of India Tourism office is at 88 Janpath — go there or your hotel reception. Refuse all "help" at stations.

# The Smaller Frustrations

- **The "shortcut" detour.** Auto-rickshaw "takes you somewhere better on the way." That somewhere is a commission shop. Refuse politely.
- **The wrong change.** Vendor returns 50 INR less than owed, claiming math error. Count change before walking away.
- **The double-counter trick.** Pay for entry, your ticket "doesn't scan," asked to pay again. Insist on speaking to the supervisor.
- **The hotel switch.** Driver says "your hotel is full/closed" and offers an alternative (paying commission). Call your hotel directly to verify.
- **The fake monk donation.** A "monk" hands you a brochure and asks for a donation toward a temple. Genuine monks do not solicit cash on streets.

## THE SINGLE UNIVERSAL RULE

If a stranger approached you with help, expect to pay for it. If you initiated the interaction, you are usually fine. The vast majority of Indians are genuinely kind and unfailingly hospitable — but the small percentage running scams are highly skilled at it. Your default should be friendly skepticism toward strangers in transit zones.

# Solo Female Travel Notes

*India is a complicated place for solo women — both more rewarding and more demanding than most destinations. Honest information helps you do it well.*

## The Reality, Honestly

Most solo female travelers in India report overwhelmingly positive experiences. They also report a constant background level of alertness that travelers to Switzerland do not need. The two are simultaneously true. India is not Sweden. It is also not the dystopia some Western media describes. The truth is closer to: very rewarding, but with rules.

## The Practical Rules

- **Dress modestly** — not because India demands it, but because it reduces unwanted attention significantly. Cover shoulders and knees in public. Loose cotton kurtas are the most comfortable hot-weather choice and signal respect for local norms.
- **Avoid being out alone after 10 p.m.** in any neighborhood you don't know. Mall Road Manali is fine until 11 p.m.; Old Delhi is not.
- **Use the women-only metro car** (first car, marked with pink stripe) during rush hours. It is a different experience from the general car.
- **Sit in the back of Uber/Ola alone.** Front-seat travel in India implies a different social relationship.
- **Share your Uber trip status** with someone — Uber has a built-in "share trip" feature. Use it for late-night rides.
- **Trust your instincts immediately.** If a situation feels wrong, leave. India has plenty of options — the next auto, the next hotel, the next street. Do not stay in a discomforting situation to avoid social awkwardness.
- **Carry a basic noisemaker** (a whistle, or a personal-alarm keychain). Almost never needed; useful to have.
- **Decline tilak, threads, and physical touch** from strangers — especially at religious sites. A polite firm "no, thank you" is enough.
- **Use Practo for video consultations** with female doctors when needed. 500 INR, English-speaking, discreet.

## Safer Choices For Your Route

|                  |                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| IN DELHI         | Sleep in South Delhi or Aerocity. Avoid Paharganj at night. Use the metro by day, Uber after dark. Khan Market, Connaught Place, Hauz Khas Village are safe in evenings.                 |
| FOR OLD DELHI    | Visit by day (before 4 p.m.). Book a guided walking tour for first visits — group setting reduces hassle significantly.                                                                  |
| ON THE NIGHT BUS | Book a single berth (not double-shared). Top berths are slightly more private. Many operators have female-only berths — ask when booking. ZingBus has explicit female-friendly policies. |
| IN MANALI        | Old Manali is genuinely safe — café culture, many Western travelers, low-key. Vashisht is also fine. Avoid walking alone after 10 p.m. on dark stretches between Manali and Vashisht.    |
| EMERGENCY        | Women's Helpline: <b>1091</b> (24/7, English supported). Indian Emergency: <b>112</b> . Save both as speed-dial.                                                                         |

### IF YOU NEED TO REFUSE POLITELY BUT FIRMLY

"Nahin chahiye" — "I don't want / don't need" — is the most useful phrase you can learn. Said firmly, it ends most unwanted interactions. "Bhai, jaiye" — "brother, please go" — works when "no thanks" hasn't. Indian social norms make sustained refusal more effective than confrontation. Avoid raising your voice unless safety requires it; volume escalates everything.

# Health, Hospitals & Delhi Belly

Most India trips include one bad-stomach day. Most are over within 24 hours. Knowing what to take and when prevents it from becoming a trip-ruining event.

## The Medical Kit To Buy On Day One

Walk into any Indian pharmacy (Apollo Pharmacy, MedPlus, 1mg, or smaller "chemists") on Day 1 in Delhi. Buy the kit below for ~500 INR total. You may not need any of it. But not having it when you need it is the problem.

| ITEM                             | INDIAN BRAND         | COST        | WHEN TO USE                                                                         |
|----------------------------------|----------------------|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Oral Rehydration Salts           | Electral / Enerzal   | 20 INR each | First sign of stomach issue. Buy 6 sachets.                                         |
| Loperamide (anti-diarrhea)       | Eldoper              | 40 INR      | Severe diarrhea, when you need to travel. Buy 10 tablets.                           |
| Ondansetron (anti-nausea)        | Emeset 4mg           | 15 INR/tab  | Vomiting. Buy 10 tablets.                                                           |
| Tinidazole (antibiotic)          | Tiniba 500mg         | 35 INR      | Persistent diarrhea past 48 hours. Take only after a doctor consult. Buy 6 tablets. |
| Azithromycin (antibiotic)        | Azithral 500mg       | 35 INR      | Bacterial infection. Doctor-prescribed only. Have on hand.                          |
| Paracetamol                      | Crocin / Dolo 650    | 25 INR      | Fever, headache, body aches.                                                        |
| Meclizine (anti-motion sickness) | Avomine              | 15 INR      | For the bus journey. Take 30 min before mountain stretches.                         |
| Antihistamine                    | Cetirizine / Allegra | 20 INR      | Dust allergies, itching, mild reactions.                                            |
| Antiseptic                       | Dettol / Savlon      | 60 INR      | Cleaning cuts, scrapes.                                                             |
| Hand sanitizer + wipes           | Any brand            | 80 INR      | Constant use.                                                                       |



## If You Get Sick — The Protocol

- **Mild diarrhea, less than 24 hours.** Rest, ORS every 2 hours, eat bland (rice, bananas, toast, plain yogurt). It will pass.
- **Diarrhea with travel needed.** Loperamide 2mg, repeat after each loose stool up to 4 tablets per day. Continue ORS.
- **Vomiting.** Ondansetron 4mg dissolved on the tongue. Sip ORS slowly.
- **Diarrhea past 48 hours.** See a doctor — likely a bacterial infection needing antibiotics. Practo video consult is fastest (500 INR, English-speaking).
- **Fever above 38.5°C, severe symptoms, blood in stool, persistent vomiting, or dehydration signs.** Go to a hospital. See list below.

## Hospitals — Where To Go If Needed

| LOCATION         | HOSPITAL                          | NOTE                                                                                       |
|------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Delhi (South)    | Max Smart Hospital, Saket         | International-standard. English-speaking. Direct insurance billing possible.               |
| Delhi (South)    | Indraprastha Apollo, Sarita Vihar | Major chain. Excellent emergency room.                                                     |
| Delhi (Aerocity) | Fortis Hospital, Vasant Kunj      | Convenient for airport-area emergencies.                                                   |
| Manali           | Lady Willingdon Hospital          | Mission hospital, established 1928. The most reliable medical care in Manali.              |
| Manali           | Manipal Hospital, Manali          | Newer chain hospital, modern facilities.                                                   |
| Telemedicine     | Practo App                        | 500 INR for English-speaking doctor consult by video. Best first step for non-emergencies. |

### PHARMACY REALITY

Indian pharmacies sell most things over the counter without prescriptions — including antibiotics. This sounds convenient but is medically risky. Use Practo to consult a doctor first for antibiotic-level issues, then buy what they recommend. Pharmacy staff usually speak basic English and are remarkably knowledgeable.

# A Working Hindi Phrasebook

You will not need Hindi to travel India — English works almost everywhere. But the moment you use even a few words, the response from locals shifts noticeably. These are the phrases worth memorizing.

## The Essential Ten

### **Namaste**

Hello / greeting

Universal. Said with hands joined at the chest. Works in any context.

### **Kitna?**

How much?

The bargaining starter. "Kit-naa?" with question intonation.

### **Haan / Nahin**

Yes / No

Basic affirmatives.

### **Theek hai**

OK / fine / agreed

"Theek hai." Used constantly for "I understand" or "let's do it."

### **Bahut zyada**

Too much / too expensive

Bargaining response. Say with a slight smile and step back.

### **Dhanyavaad**

Thank you

"Dhan-ya-vaad." More formal than "shukriya," which is also fine.

### **Nahin chahiye**

I don't want / need

"Na-heen cha-hee-ye." For declining touts politely but firmly.

### **Bhai / Didi**

Brother / Sister

Respectful way to address young men / women. Use freely.

### **Meter chalu karo**

Start the meter

Essential auto-rickshaw phrase. Say firmly before getting in.

### **Paani**

Water

"Paa-nee." Critical word. Useful at restaurants, stalls, anywhere.

## Useful In Specific Situations

### **Bilkul nahin**

Absolutely not

Stronger refusal. For persistent touts.

### **Kahan hai...?**

Where is...?

Followed by the place name. "Kahan hai metro?"

### **Mirchi kam**

Less spicy

Order this when ordering Indian food. Save your taste buds.

### **Photo le sakta hoon?**

May I take a photo?

Always ask before photographing people. Most say yes warmly.

### **Maaf kijiye**

Excuse me / sorry

"Maaf kee-jee-ye." Polite "excuse me" in any context.

### **Khaana**

Food

"Kha-naa." General word.

### **Dhire dhire**

Slowly slowly

Useful for drivers, walking guides, or people speaking too fast.

### **Madat chahiye**

I need help

Emergency phrase. Said firmly, it summons help quickly.

## Numbers Worth Knowing

| HINDI  | NUMBER | HINDI  | NUMBER |
|--------|--------|--------|--------|
| Ek     | 1      | Saat   | 7      |
| Do     | 2      | Aath   | 8      |
| Teen   | 3      | Nau    | 9      |
| Chaar  | 4      | Das    | 10     |
| Paanch | 5      | Sau    | 100    |
| Chhe   | 6      | Hazaar | 1,000  |

# Three Budget Levels

Estimated full-trip cost for 8 days, per person, excluding international flights.

All figures in INR. Approximate USD shown at 83 INR per USD.

| CATEGORY                            | BUDGET          | MID-RANGE       | PREMIUM           |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|-------------------|
| Delhi Hotel × 3 nights              | 2,400           | 12,000          | 45,000            |
| Manali Hotel × 3 nights             | 2,400           | 10,500          | 30,000            |
| Delhi → Manali bus (return)         | 2,000           | 3,600           | 5,000             |
| Meals × 8 days                      | 4,000           | 10,000          | 28,000            |
| Monument entry fees                 | 2,400           | 2,400           | 2,400             |
| Transport in Delhi (3 days)         | 1,200           | 3,000           | 8,000             |
| Sissu day taxi (per person, shared) | 800             | 1,500           | 4,000             |
| Manali activities (paragliding etc) | 1,000           | 3,500           | 8,000             |
| Shopping & souvenirs                | 1,000           | 4,000           | 15,000            |
| SIM Card + apps                     | 600             | 600             | 600               |
| Miscellaneous + contingency         | 1,500           | 3,000           | 8,000             |
| <b>Total in INR</b>                 | <b>~19,300</b>  | <b>~54,100</b>  | <b>~154,000</b>   |
| <b>Total in USD (approx)</b>        | <b>~232 USD</b> | <b>~652 USD</b> | <b>~1,855 USD</b> |
| <b>Total in EUR (approx)</b>        | <b>~215 EUR</b> | <b>~605 EUR</b> | <b>~1,720 EUR</b> |

## What Each Level Actually Looks Like

### BUDGET LEVEL

Hostels in Old Manali, budget guesthouses in Delhi, non-AC sleeper bus, street food and dhabas, metro and shared autos, free monuments + 2–3 ticketed sites, basic Solang activity, taxi to Sissu shared 4-ways. Doable, real, fine.

|                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>MID-RANGE LEVEL</b> | Mid-range hotels (Holiday Inn / Apple Country / Bloomrooms), Volvo AC sleeper bus, mix of sit-down restaurants and street food, Uber + occasional driver, all monuments + audio guides, paragliding at Solang, private taxi to Sissu shared 2-ways. <b>Our recommendation for Jessica.</b> |
| <b>PREMIUM LEVEL</b>   | Luxury hotels (The Imperial / Span Resort), ZingBus Max sleeper, fine-dining + curated restaurant list, hired car + driver for the whole trip, premium guided tours, helicopter view of Manali (winter), private taxi to Sissu solo. The maximum extraction of comfort from the route.     |

#### WHAT THIS DOESN'T INCLUDE

International flights (Frankfurt → Delhi return is typically 600–1,000 EUR depending on season and timing — book 6–8 weeks ahead for best rates), travel insurance (~70–120 USD), e-Visa (25 USD), and personal extras (alcohol, massages, additional sightseeing if you extend).

# The Packing List

A complete checklist for Delhi (warm city) + Manali (cool mountains). Tick as you pack. Skip anything you genuinely won't need – but read every item.

## Clothing

- |                                                                                                          |                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Lightweight T-shirts × 4</b><br>Breathable cotton or linen – your daily wear | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Long-sleeve shirts × 2</b><br>For temples, sun, mosquitoes, evenings |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Fleece or light down jacket</b><br>Manali nights, mountain stretches         | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Waterproof windbreaker</b><br>Sudden mountain showers, dust          |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Walking trousers × 2</b><br>Lightweight, quick-dry. Not heavy jeans.         | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Shorts × 1-2</b><br>For Delhi heat, hotel comfort. Modest length.    |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Scarf / dupatta</b><br>Temple cover, sun, dust, emergency blanket            | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Underwear × 7</b><br>Skipping a wash day saves stress                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Socks × 6</b><br>Including 2 warm wool pairs for Manali                      | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Walking shoes</b><br>Most important item – broken in already         |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Sandals</b><br>Easy on/off for temples, hotel, casual evenings               | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Sleepwear</b><br>Modest enough for hostel emergencies                |

## Documents & Money

- |                                                                                              |                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Passport (original)</b><br>+ photocopy stored separately         | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>e-Visa printout × 2</b><br>Plus a digital copy on your phone                   |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Passport photos × 4</b><br>SIM card, Sissu permits, just in case | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Return flight ticket (printed)</b><br>Some immigration officers ask            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Hotel bookings (printed)</b><br>First nights at minimum          | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Travel insurance details</b><br>Policy number, emergency phone, claims process |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>EUR/USD cash</b><br>200–300 EUR for emergencies                  | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Travel card (Wise / Revolut)</b><br>Plus backup credit card stored separately  |

## Health & Hygiene

- |                                                                                     |                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Sunscreen SPF 50+</b><br>Delhi sun + Manali altitude UV | <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Lip balm with SPF</b><br>Altitude dries lips severely |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

- ☐ **Insect repellent (DEET)**  
*Mostly for evenings; not malaria risk*
- ☐ **Tissues + wet wipes**  
*Constant use, public toilets*
- ☐ **Sunglasses**  
*Delhi and Manali both bright*

- ☐ **Hand sanitizer**  
*Two small bottles*
- ☐ **Personal medications**  
*Bring 2x the dose you need, in original packaging*
- ☐ **Reusable water bottle (1L)**  
*Refill from purified sources at hotels*

## Tech & Gear

- ☐ **Unlocked smartphone**  
*For local SIM card*
- ☐ **Universal adapter (Type D/M)**  
*India sockets*
- ☐ **Earphones**  
*Bus journey, crowded spaces*
- ☐ **Offline translator (Hindi)**  
*Google Translate Hindi pack*

- ☐ **Power bank (10,000+ mAh)**  
*Essential for bus journey*
- ☐ **Camera**  
*Phone usually sufficient; serious camera for landscapes*
- ☐ **Offline maps downloaded**  
*Google Maps offline, Delhi + Manali*
- ☐ **Small padlock**  
*Hostel lockers, luggage zip*

# Emergency Numbers & Embassies

Save these to your phone before you fly. The probability you will need any of them is low. The cost of having them ready is zero.

## National Emergency Numbers

| SERVICE                 | NUMBER    | NOTES                                                                                  |
|-------------------------|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Universal Emergency     | 112       | India's 911 equivalent. Routes to police, fire, ambulance. English-speaking operators. |
| Police                  | 100       | Direct line to police                                                                  |
| Fire                    | 101       | Direct line to fire services                                                           |
| Ambulance               | 102 / 108 | 108 is more reliable in cities                                                         |
| Women's Helpline        | 1091      | 24/7, English supported. Save as speed-dial.                                           |
| Tourist Helpline        | 1363      | Multilingual, 24/7. Run by Ministry of Tourism.                                        |
| Senior Citizen Helpline | 14567     | For elderly travelers                                                                  |
| Child Helpline          | 1098      | Report any child welfare concern                                                       |

## German Embassy & Consular Help

|                     |                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| EMBASSY IN DELHI    | <b>Embassy of the Federal Republic of Germany</b><br>6/50G Shantipath, Chanakyapuri, New Delhi 110021<br>Phone: +91-11-44199199<br>Emergency (after hours): +91-11-44199199 (press 9) |
| WORKING HOURS       | Monday–Friday, 8:30 a.m. to 12:00 p.m. for visa and consular services. Emergencies 24/7.                                                                                              |
| EMAIL               | info@new-delhi.diplo.de                                                                                                                                                               |
| WHAT THEY HELP WITH | Lost or stolen passport (emergency replacement), serious medical or criminal incidents, repatriation in extreme cases. Not: routine travel advice, hotel bookings, lost luggage.      |



## Hospitals (Quick Reference)

|                  |                                                                                                                   |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DELHI · BEST ER  | <b>Max Smart Hospital, Saket</b> — +91-11-26515050. International-standard, English-speaking.                     |
| DELHI · AEROCITY | <b>Fortis Vasant Kunj</b> — +91-11-42776222. Closest to the airport.                                              |
| MANALI           | <b>Lady Willingdon Mission Hospital</b> — +91-1902-252379. Reliable, decades of experience with foreign patients. |
| MANALI · MODERN  | <b>Manipal Hospital Manali</b> — Check current number locally. Newer chain.                                       |

## Tourist Police

|                      |                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DELHI TOURIST POLICE | Special tourism-focused police units at major tourist sites. Helpful, English-speaking, recognizable by yellow armbands. Major presence at Red Fort, India Gate, Connaught Place. |
| TOURISM OFFICE       | Government of India Tourism Office: 88 Janpath, New Delhi. The only legitimate "tourist information centre" in Delhi — everything else with that name is a private agency.        |

## If You Lose Your Passport

1. **File a police FIR** at the nearest station. Get a stamped copy — you will need it.
2. **Contact the German Embassy** at +91-11-44199199. They issue Emergency Travel Documents within 24–48 hours.
3. **Have ready:** passport photocopy (you packed two), passport photos × 2, the FIR, proof of return ticket, ~80 EUR fee.
4. **Notify your travel insurance** — most policies cover replacement-passport costs.

— B E Y O N D     T H E     T A J —

*The best journeys do not begin at the airport.  
They begin in the months of decision before the  
trip — and they end weeks after you are home,  
in conversations with people who don't quite  
understand what you saw.*

*We hope this blueprint serves you well. Use it as  
a map, not a script. India will give you what  
you bring to it.*

*Safe travels, Jessica. Komm gut zurück.*